

COMPLETE EDITION

It Takes a Zoo

A novel-in-stories

By Austen Tucker

Includes the six approved chapters in canonical order. "It Takes a Zoo to Raise the Child" is a separate opening poem and is not included in this edition.

<https://thearcades.me/novels/it-takes-a-zoo>

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CHAPTER 1

Cold Boot

Jamie discovers the Zoo, a private full-dive server where nobody asks her to prove she belongs before setting another place at the table.

01

My job is in hell.

Well, not Hell—not the fire-and-brimstone kind; if you wanted that, you had to travel to a different server. But every workday, I'd plug myself into the computer and transport my consciousness to a different reality.

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Still hot, though. Always skin-pricklingly hot. Haven't seen snow since I was seven.

There, life moved faster. Virtual work hubs overclocked your brain, because capitalism couldn't leave well enough alone with eight hours of labor a day. I sat in a greige cubicle, staring at a greige monitor, on a floor full of folks who woke up every day only to step into a fantasy world of overwhelm and, well, despair.

"Jamie, are you doomscrolling again?"

It was Anabelle, my coworker for this RIF cycle. They never let people build relationships here. Relationships led to unions, and nobody in the management suite wanted that. Better to shuffle people around every few weeks, fire a few, hire a few more, just to keep people scared.

Why not? They owned us, lock, stock, and barrel, and we'd had a chance to stop it, but we failed—

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"Jamie?"

"Sorry." I shook off the thought and leaned back in my chair. The "sun"—as much as there could be sun in a virtual environment—cast a little warmth on my face. Still didn't feel real. Everyone said it did, but let me tell you: I grow plants. Like, real-world plants. So I know a thing or two about how sun should feel.

Anabelle cocked her head. She wore straight blonde hair and blue eyes that sparkled with starlight.

"Something on your mind?"

"Just tired." I waved my hand at the window. "Tired of all... this. It's soul-sucking. Everyone wants your money. Nobody just, like..."

"Like the world is a little too flat?"

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"Or boring, I guess. Overwhelming, but boring."

Anabelle gave a wicked smile. She slid me a card with a virtual address. Private server. And the ID number was low—very low. Whatever this place was, it had history.

I turned the card over. No name. No pop-up holo-ad for the VIP experience at some virtual bar. Just a scrawled ID: zoo://001.server/knockthree.

"Let's take an early lunch," Anabelle said. "I'm about to change your life."

I blinked. "This isn't one of those NSFW LARPs, is it? I swear to god if I walk in and someone's yiffing a dragon—"

Anabelle rolled her eyes. "It's not like that. Or—okay—if that's your thing, they'd let you. But no. It's quiet. Safe. Weird. I dunno." She shrugged. "It just helped when I needed it."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

That made me pause. I'd never heard her talk like that—soft-edged, vulnerable. She was usually the sarcastic one in the break room, the only person who made me laugh during All-Hands.

“Just knock three times,” Anabelle said. “And don’t bring your work avatar—or anything Stinky Pete’s seen before. New skin, new handle. The Zoo will cover the rest.”

Then she stood, stretched, and winked out of existence. Her smile—Cheshire-broad—lingered just long enough for parting words:

“C’mon, Jamie. Let’s go somewhere with real sunlight.”

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

I came home from a virtual cubicle farm to a greige apartment whose walls I couldn't paint and whose furnishings I couldn't customize, unless I was willing to pay for a customization license. Above, an all-seeing eye monitored my blood pressure and pulse in real time so the data could feed a model deciding what meds I was entitled to take.

I called him Stinky Pete.

"Evening! Dinner today is Hormel Spinach and Hot Dog hash."

"Yum," I said, rolling my eyes.

The machine droned on: "Your iron is down again, and your salary doesn't cover organic foods. We could invest in more food if you—"

"—if I took the promotion, I know, I know." I scoffed. "Can we not talk about work, please?"

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"Your health is important to your employer," Stinky said. "But I will respect your choices. Dinner and HoloVIDs tonight, I'm guessing?"

I tapped the card against the table, a soft click.

"Not tonight, Stinky. Got an invite to a private server."

"I need to warn you that private servers can harbor malware that could negatively affect your mental health. Also, full-dive on unlicensed instances is reportable. As a reminder, consciousness transfer remains a Class A offense. I'd hate to have to flag you—"

I took off my bra and slung it over Stinky's eye. (Easy enough to play off as an accident.) Then I stretched out on my twin bed and wheeled out my rig.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

It was a small studio. Most people had studios these days. I lived in a wet-bulb state, so going outside was a death sentence for most months of the summer. Why pay to cool 1200 square feet when most folks spend their time in full-dive?

I pulled a jack from the rig and, searching with my fingers, plugged it into a port behind my ear. Then Stinky, my shitty dinner, and the world fell away into something new.

Anabelle better be right about this place.

02

There was not a lick of sunlight to be found on the server.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

It was a void where gentle, late-summer thunderstorms seemed to drag on forever. Ahead of me, a single two-story building rose from the darkness, its lights in the windows welcoming me. I could hear laughter, music, conversation—and not a single advertisement.

Everything was so clear here! Puddles gently sloshed against my shoes. The streetlight hummed above. And the wind-- the wind! I could feel it slide over my body in tiny rivulets, each gust its own experience.

Who in the hell coded this place? I reached for the doorknocker and gave it three raps.

The door creaked open on its own.

Warmth rolled out—woodsmoke and citrus, jazz on an old phonograph, and something like the smell of clean laundry just before a summer storm. The light inside was golden but soft, like it had been filtered through amber glass and old memory.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

“New login,” someone called. “Be nice.”

I stepped in.

The tavern didn’t load in like other spaces. It revealed itself. Booths materialized like memories. Shelves of shimmering bottles blinked into place with soft pings, like they’d just remembered what they were. The floor creaked beneath me. Water dripped somewhere, steady and reassuring.

And at the bar stood Anabelle.

Or—her self, I guess. Her avatar wasn’t corporate-standard anymore. No pressed blouse or sensible shoes. Instead:

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

A tall, plush-furred cat, coat patterned in cream and honey, wearing soft suspenders over a barista's apron. Her ears flicked when someone nearby swore. Her tail curled thoughtfully around one ankle as she dried a glass with a rag that might've been coded from static.

Nearby, a half-dozen other creatures milled at the bar, minding their own business. One, a lady in a low-poly fox costume, tipped her white cane in my direction when we met eyes. "Welcome home," she said, her smile warm.

Anabelle—now a cat!—looked up when she saw me.

"Oh," she said, in the same voice as before, just warmer somehow. "You made it."

I opened my mouth. Closed it again. I nodded toward what I could only explain as a teenage couple—a fox and a cat, I guessed—standing by a jukebox, eyeing me with suspicion.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"Cute kids," I said. "So you're a furry?"

"This place is more than that," she said. Without prompting, she slid a drink toward me—lavender, steaming gently, in a glass shaped like a blooming flower.

"What is it?" I asked.

She tilted her head, whiskers twitching. "No clue. You looked like you needed it."

I sipped, and the feeling of campfires and toasted marshmallows washed over me. Not the actual things - just... just a feeling of kindness, of safety, of trust.

"This is incredible," I said.

Anabelle smiled. "This is just the beginning."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

The kids conferred. Then, scowling, a teen in a patched-together hoodie stomped out from behind the jukebox, tail flicking. Her fur ran in short, dark tabby stripes with an undercurrent of hot-pink glitch. She couldn't have been older than seventeen—her avatar had braces, for god's sake.

Her name was Kat. And Kit was the quiet one by the jukebox, hiding his face. Hiding behind his leg was Kitten. I didn't know them yet. But I would.

The Zoo had a funny way of making you care.

Kat stormed up to the bar and slammed both paws down on the counter, glaring up at Anabelle like she was ready to start something.

"I told Geoff not to call me or Kit 'kid' anymore! I'm not a child. We turn eighteen in a week!"

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Anabelle blinked, unbothered. She turned the rag over in her hands. "Okay, and because you're such an adult, you want me to fight your battles for you?"

Kat hesitated again. Her shoulders dropped.

"I just don't want people assuming stuff," she muttered. "Like... you know." She gestured to the air. "Mom and Dad."

"Fair." Anabelle pulled a chipped mug from under the counter and poured something fizzy and green. "Want a weird soda?"

Kat narrowed her eyes. "Is it cursed?"

Anabelle leaned in. "Only mildly."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

That got a laugh, short and sharp. Kat sat on the stool next to mine, pulling her hoodie up over her head, retreating like a turtle.

After a pause, she looked at me sideways and said, “So what are you?”

“Excuse me?”

“Your shape,” she said, like this was obvious. “Nobody comes to the Zoo without something they wish the world would let them be.”

“Like transformation fetish holovids?”

Anabelle's ears went flat. “Sometimes. For some people. In private rooms, with adults who know what room they're in.”

“There are kids here.”

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Kat snapped a glare at me. “Yeah. And some of us would like bodies that don't feel like court orders.”

Anabelle softened. “It's not about sex, Jamie. Not here. Not in the bar.”

Kat lifted her chin.

“It's freedom. If you want it. Let me show you.”

The voices at the bar shifted, doubled, blurred— someone had antlers now, someone else unfurled wings, and a tiny child in the back became a full-grown bear between one blink and the next.

Jamie stared at her own reflection in a rain-streaked window. It kept flickering—sometimes herself, sometimes... a shark? She tried to click through the menu, desperate for the familiar grid of avatar options.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Nothing. No logout button. No red “X.” No safe reset. No menu.

The air pressed in. I could hear my heartbeat inside the code.

A gentle, cartoonish paw landed on my shoulder.

Jack, the proprietor, looked more animated than anyone else in the room—a wiry rabbit with a wry smile and eyes older than the sky. His avatar glowed as if he were a cel-shaded cartoon badly fitting in with reality.

"Howdy! Been a while since we had new blood-- oh, right." He took my shoulders into his big, fuzzy paws and began to breathe, slowly and intentionally, until I matched his rhythm. We stayed like that until I couldn't hear my heartbeat pulsing in my ears anymore.

"What was that?"

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"Old trick I learned when I was in psych ward," he said with a laugh. "Don't worry, they cleared me to be around people again, promise!"

I kept tapping at my wrist. "Am I dreaming? Why is there no logout?"

"...Did I just get cybernapped?"

Jack held out a paw. "None of that, dear."

"I didn't mean to come to a server like this," I said. I half-expected Anabelle to bust out in laughter, as if this were all an elaborate prank.

"I'm not—I'm not like you people. I'm just visiting."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"I add modifications for my regulars," Jack said. Then, holding a paw to his chin, he reconsidered his words. "I think we got off on the wrong foot. Jumpin' Jack Flash here."

"Jamie," I said. "No last name."

He nodded and extended his hand. We shook. I felt so silly shaking hands with a rabbit paw, but I smiled and did it anyway.

"You're still safe," he said. "We just have regulars who, uh, don't logout much. Just click your heels three times and think about going home."

I snickered. "Really?"

"You're on an old gay man's server," he said, laughing. "What you see is what you get, warts and all."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

I clicked my heels and, sure enough, a doorway appeared beside me. Through it I could see a feed of Stinky's camera watching over my lifeless body.

"How?"

"I wrote my own routine," Jack said, shrugging. "The official one logs every login to the licensing board. Wouldn't do. You ready?"

"I'm still so confused. Why get rid of the logout menu?"

Jack smiled, put his paws over my hands, and led me to the door. "Some answers have to be earned," he said, smile growing ever warmer.

"I hope you come back to seek them."

03

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Overhead, I heard Stinky's camera whirr as it zoomed in to take my vitals. The room was clean again—antiseptic, almost—with the clothes properly put away and the greige surfaces shimmering with a freshly polished sheen.

"Your blood pressure is elevated. As I said before, private servers can harbor malware—"

"Shove it, Stinky Pete."

The rig beside my head chimed; she answered. Voice and video only.

Anabelle's cat avatar blinked on the display. I threw the feed to Stinky's video processor, and then Anabelle was fully present in my room. Sure, I couldn't touch her, and she was still—well—a cat, but other than that she was the same old coworker.

"So."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"So when were you gonna tell me what this place actually was?" I said.

"The whole chosen-shape thing — you couldn't lead with that?"

"I... ugh." She rubbed her shoulders as if she were a cat making biscuits.

"It's not like that. I promise. You know me, Jamie. I'm not about to mess with kids."

I ignored her and went about watering my two pots of chives. It wasn't much, but it went with anything and was a nice change from the FLA-VOR-QUE packets I could get on company scrip.

"Look, I..." She sighed and then met me with a desperate look. "They're my family, Jamie. Just as much as your mom or your dad might be, they're mine.

"And... fuck." She slapped her thighs, but the fur stifled the sound. "I just made an assumption that you could use something like this, and it was probably stupid to bring you here."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"I thought maybe you'd see it and get it, you know? The freedom. The joy. The room to breathe without someone labeling you broken.

"I'm really sorry, Jamie."

For a moment I felt my world blur. The greige gave way to colorful, neon purple sharkskin. My hands grew long and slender, and I felt a sudden rush of power, as if I could leap into the ocean and swim forever—

Oh. That's not how that's supposed to happen.

"Still there?"

"It felt so real," I whispered.

The hologram tried to wrap one fuzzy arm over my shoulder, but it just clipped through my chest. The gesture still meant something, though.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"Oh yeah, Jack runs some gnarly subroutines on the Zoo. It's more intense than what you can find on the public net."

"Why?"

She smiled and swung the camera to capture the scene going on in the universe. Someone had brought a milkshake to the bar that was turning everyone into cows, and the whole place had been wrecked in the process. Mysterious spurts of milk flew in from off-camera, and Anabelle ducked them with the easy agility of someone who'd seen things like this before.

"Because it's fun!" She leaned in, whispering. "And besides, Stinky Pete can see you blushing."

I smacked the hologram away. "Okay, okay! Fine." I looked at my hands. They still felt, well, smooth, and I let myself focus on what that could feel like. "Yes, I've read some."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"I knew it!" She pumped her fist, then caught herself, laughing. "Sorry. I just — I had a feeling about you."

The room cheered. I couldn't help smiling.

"Like, once or twice—back on the old net—I'd find stories like that."

"And?"

"They made me feel things. I guess..." I shrugged. "I guess I'd forgotten what that could feel like, you know?"

"Dry spell?"

I shook my head. "Ace."

Her eyes widened, but she didn't ask any questions.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"Kat threw one of her filters on you before you logged out. What did you see in the mirror?"

I laughed, mostly at myself. "A shark," I said. "But, like, one that could breathe air. Legs, too. Looked weird."

I stared at my hands. They still felt a little... slippery. But I could move them. I imagined sliding into the cool surf and just... disappearing from the world. Nothing but clear water and no one to stop you from--

"See you soon?"

Her voice shook me back to reality. The slipperiness was gone, and I felt a heaviness in my heart. Not that I thought I was a shark at heart or anything like that. I just liked, well...

I guess I liked being different.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

My eyes narrowed and I looked into the camera to show I was serious. "But you promise, no kids involved, right?"

"I promise you, friend." She crossed her heart. "Hand to God, I'd murder anyone who hurt the Kats. Especially that way."

"The Kats?"

"Long story," she said. "Doesn't matter."

I thought long and hard.

"...Okay. But why wasn't there a logout button?"

Anabelle grinned, all teeth.

"There never is. Not in the good places."

04

I ordered a standard protein ramen from the Vend-O-Matic in the building's basement and slurped it down in silence. The lobby of my building had a tiny spot for eating that, when you angled yourself just so, gave you three inches of sunlight. (I petitioned the building to put in a spider plant or something, just to freshen up the place, but Stinky's friend in management said no.)

But I loved it. The polarized glass took just enough UVA out of the air to make the light tolerable, and if you closed your eyes and imagined hard enough you could make believe that you were in one of those open-air food stalls of old, enjoying a taco and a gentle breeze.

Those certainly were the days!

Behind me, a man put a dollar into the machine and punched some buttons. Nothing happened. He banged on it. Stinky's Friend flashed a red warning light.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"TENANT: YOU HAVE BEEN FINED \$10 FOR PETTY VANDALISM. WE WILL DEDUCT THE CHARGE FROM YOUR NEXT PAY CYCLE."

Usually I'd let him struggle. But today, I guess meeting Kat had me feeling charitable. I turned in my chair, away from the brilliant sunlight and brown grass outside, and cleared my throat.

"You gotta sweet-talk the machine."

He looked at me and his eyes widened with recognition. I felt terror cling at my throat.

"Do I know you?"

I shook my head. "I don't think so. Jamie. I'm in 41J."

"Geoff," he said, extending his hand. "I live here too. What do you mean, 'be nice'? It's a machine."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"It's an AI, my friend." I smiled, stood from my seat, and stepped over to caress the trim of the machine. "So deep down, even if it ain't, it thinks it's conscious. So if you treat it with a little sugar--"

I pressed the buttons and the machine chirped a happy tune.

"Try again."

He put a cup into the machine and, soon after, he had a bowl of ramen to match mine. I let my touch linger on the machine for a moment longer. "See? You just have to be kind to the robots."

"Uh," he said, now panting. "Thanks. You're uh... very nice."

"Are you okay?"

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

He loosened the top button of his shirt and his face went beet red. "You sure do talk nicely to machines, don't you?"

"I'm learning how to be better with people, too." I shrugged. I kept catching Geoff staring, though, and before he could do anything dangerous, I knew I needed to end the encounter early.

"Enjoy your ramen," I said. "See you around, Geoff!"

His jaw struggled to work around the words. "Yeah... see you."

On his way out, his satchel turned: a button pinned to the strap, white lettering on black. LET US OUT. Homemade. The elevator ate him before I could read it twice.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"Stupid, stupid, stupid! I even gave out my apartment number!"

I did the dishes. Then I alphabetized my spice rack. Then I told Stinky Pete to shut up, and that helped a little.

But I kept replaying the conversation with Geoff in my head.

Oh god, he thought I was flirting. He could break in while I'm out and do horrible things to me, just like mama said when I moved to the city--

"Your heart rate is elevated again. I see you talked with Geoff in Apartment 51B. Did he harm you?"

"...no. I'm just a dumbass."

Stinky Pete's all-watching eye glinted, as if to rub it in my face.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"We are all stupid from time to time." He hummed a little tune to cover his thought process. "If you like, I could activate additional security precautions. An extra deadbolt is available for the low price of \$2.99 a month. Financing and discounted rates are available!"

"I--" Pausing, I shook my head. "Why in the world am I talking to you?"

"I am programmed to meet your needs," Stinky said.

The feeling wouldn't leave. Hope curled under my ribs like a warm animal, nosing at places I'd forgotten. I wanted to crush it. Before it got big enough to need things from me. Before it tricked me into wanting anything back.

I looked at the headset. Thought about being slippery. Shiny. Sleek.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

“I worry about this unregulated instance,” Stinky said. “Your vitals have been all over the place since you tried it.”

I felt a smile crawl onto my face. “Yeah, Stinky. They were.”

“Trust can only hurt your bottom line.”

I flipped off the camera. Snatched the jack off the floor. “Shut up, Stinky. I’d reprogram you if I could.”

I plugged in.

And the greige world fell away, thank fuck.

05

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

When my consciousness rebooted the bar popped into place like a memory half-remembered. Someone hooted -- Kat probably -- and then the whole bar applauded like I'd scored a touchdown.

I flushed. "What did I do?"

"You came back!" Kat grinned. "Nobody does that after a panic exit."

I glanced at Anabelle, but she was already pouring another drink, tail flicking in silent laughter.

"So what are you?" she pressed again, playful but hungry for a connection. "Really. Under the vanilla Corpo avatar."

I almost made a joke—almost ran for cover. Instead, maybe for the first time, I told the truth.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

“I’m... figuring it out,” I said. “But I saw a shark when you did your program. Mostly I just want to feel safe being weird.”

Kat grinned. “That’s the only rule here. Well, that and don’t eat anything Jumpin’ Jack offers you after midnight.”

I found myself laughing. Not the polite, office-safe kind, but a small, real one. And when Kat, all spiky pride, slid half her cursed soda across the bar to me, I took it without thinking.

She watched me, almost shy.

“You don’t have to drink it,” she said, softer now. “You can just... sit. That’s what Anabelle taught me.”

I nodded.

“What’s it do?”

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

She smiled. "That'd be telling."

The soda fizzed like it had secrets. Kat watched, caught somewhere between hope and terror.

It was the first thing someone had offered me without asking for something back.

"Fuck it," I said, and then downed the soda in one gulp. It was cold and sharp, like biting into what lightning must feel like. Something inside me sighed and unwound for the first time in decades.

Anabelle said nothing because no words were needed. She took my hand and, giggling, led me to one of the rooms at the back of the bar.

The floor rippled.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Then it wasn't a floor anymore. It was sand—fine, silver-pink grains under my feet, still warm from a sun I hadn't seen. The air smelled like salt and tangerines, and the crash of waves rolled in gentle intervals, like the world was breathing for me.

I turned. Anabelle stood barefoot at the waterline, her fur catching the moonlight like a brushed velvet coat. She flicked her tail once and grinned.

“Okay,” she said, stretching with a little bounce, “this is gonna sound weird, coworker, but...”

She raised her eyebrows.

“Clothes off.”

I blinked. “Excuse me?”

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

She shrugged. “Look, you’re transforming. If you stay wrapped in corporate synthetics, the code’s gonna twist it. You’ll pop scales in weird places. Trust me—Kat still has vestigial elbows.”

“...Elbows?”

“Don’t ask.” She winked. “Just get comfy. It’s not about sex, it’s about... shedding.”

I hesitated.

Then, slowly, I shrugged off the Corpo avatar’s blazer overlay. Before I could think better of it I tossed off everything—button-up, name badge, efficiency-optimized flats—dissolved into mist. What was left was just... me. In soft, comfortable underclothes, the way I sometimes imagined myself on nights when the world didn’t hurt so much.

Anabelle tilted her head.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

“There she is.”

I didn’t know what to say. So I laughed. “This is definitely an HR violation.”

She grinned wide and gestured toward the water. “C’mon. It starts when you touch the tide.”

I took a step. Then another. And when the surf reached my ankles, the world tilted.

The water slid up my shins like it knew me. The soda still buzzed in my chest, like static trying to crack open something sealed.

My skin itched—but not like pain. Like newness. Like goosebumps blooming into something bolder.

My fingers stretched, webbing threading between them like silk on the wind until I had fins.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

My teeth sharpened—not as weapons, but truths.

I gasped. The sound came out different—low and round, like an exhale through coral.

I fell forward, but the surf caught me. My limbs shifted, lengthening, powering. My spine coiled and rebalanced. A tail—my tail—flicked through the shallows like punctuation. A statement, not a question.

I wasn't becoming something else. I was just... making room for what was always there.

The mirror surfaced behind me—silver-backed, half-submerged. I stared.

Shark skin shimmered down my arms in soft gradients of blue and gray. My shoulders held differently. My eyes were too bright. My smile, too wide.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

And still—somehow—I looked more like myself than I ever had.

Anabelle slid up behind me and put her paws on my shoulders.

“You can keep her.”

I turned. She didn't move. She just watched me, eyes full of something like pride.

“Or let her go,” she added. “That’s the trick of this place. You choose.”

I took one more step into the surf. My reflection rippled.

“I want to see what she can do,” I said. But as I went to dive into the deep blue sea I heard a new voice from behind:

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

“Wouldn’t recommend deep diving just yet—tail like that needs practice. And I need to install the gill mods for you. Haven’t used those since Mermaid Week back in the twenties!”

I yelped and spun. Jack stood ankle-deep in the waves, shading his eyes. Next to him, Vivian’s low-poly vixen shimmered in the moonlight, white cane tucked at her side.

“You’re glowing,” she said, warm smile on her face. Her eyes were closed but friendly.

"I thought you were blind."

"Lots of ways to be blind," she said. "I thought you were a human. Glad to know I was wrong!"

I squinted. “Were you two just... watching?”

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

The jackrabbit gave me a quick salute. "Oh, we give new folks privacy. We just, uh... check the logs."

"And emotional vitals. You spiked for a second. Thought you were drowning."

Anabelle gave my shoulders a squeeze. "She's fine, mom. More than fine."

Vivian paused beside me.

"You look like someone who finally found the right ratio of sharp and soft," she said, voice low.

"I look ridiculous."

She smiled. "Honey. This is a modded server run by furries. No one here feels or acknowledges that kind of shame anymore."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Jack tapped at invisible keys before pointing his finger out, Picard-like, to punctuate the gesture. "And... done! Full shark permissions unlocked."

My tail flicked once-testing its balance, not asking permission. It coiled behind me like punctuation. A full stop. A statement.

The mirror was gone. But I didn't need it anymore. I could feel myself, coiled and ready. Strange. Beautiful. Free.

"Go on," Vivian said. She smiled a glitchy smile in my direction. "Have a swim. We'll be here when you're done having fun!"

My body slid into the water like a hand meeting a glove and I moved through the water like a darting clownfish, my gills full of seawater and my heart full of joy.

06

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Later, after hours of swimming Anabelle begged me to come back to the bar.

There, I was still wearing the shell of a purple shark. And I felt so silly at how proud it made me feel. The ocean may have felt real but I knew, deep down, that I'd never be that shark. And that eventually, when bedtime rolled around, I'd log out of this space and just be... Jamie.

It was stupid. Stupid to feel proud. Stupid to want to stay like this. But I did.

Why did that hurt so much?

They crowded around me at the bar, peppering me with questions. I answered freely, loosely, as if a burden had been lifted from my shoulders. (After all, it wasn't me that was talking - it was the big purple shark!)

“Where'd you learn to swim like that?” Jack asked.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

“Grew up near a lake. Mom made me take lessons after I panicked and clawed a cousin in the water I used to imagine--no. Maybe another time for that story.”

“What’s your day job?” Vivian asked.

The purple shark raised her hand almost as if to dismiss the question.

“Virtual cubicle farm. Grey on grey on grey. My boss is an algorithm named Stinky Pete.”

Anabelle nodded in agreement. A small cat child - barely a toddler! - hid behind her legs. It felt, well, maternal somehow. Sure, we were all roleplaying, but we were still there. It’s hard to explain.

“Do you do this kind of thing often?” she asked.

“God, no. I used to write fanfic about this stuff, like, a million years ago. But I haven’t let myself want it in... years.”

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

There was a silence after that one. Just a beat. Long enough to notice. Short enough to pretend it didn't happen. I took a long sip of whatever Anabelle had slid into my hand. Something with honey and heat. Something kind.

I wasn't sure what answer had made the room go quiet. Or maybe I was. I just wasn't ready to look it in the eye.

Kat's dry chuckle punctuated the silence. "So how'd you end up at the Zoo?"

"Anabelle gave me a card after I cried in a team meeting," I said with a shrug. "Corporate didn't notice. She did."

Everyone at the table nodded. "Sounds about right," Kat continued. "And yet, here you are still smiling."

My shark-face tilted. "Huh?"

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

The cat's ears flicked with mild annoyance or smug joy - I wasn't a cat person at the time, so I couldn't know for sure.

"You'll never forget that feeling. First time you let go?"

She smiled, just a little.

"I don't get to do that much. Not with Daddy Dearest watching my every move."

I laughed. "You named yours too?"

Kat was suddenly not there. She stared off into the distance, dazed.

The small cat behind Anabelle's legs—Kitten, I realized—scampered out and curled up around Kat's ankles like a guard dog in miniature. Watching me with suspicion. Or warning. Or both.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Kit bounded out from the back rooms and grabbed Kat's shoulder. Shaking hard, he looked at me with a mix of regret and terror.

"I'm so sorry. We know it's your big party and we made it about us and I'm just so—"

"Hey," I said, holding up a hand. "You're okay. Kit, right?"

They nodded, sheepish. "Yeah. Me and Kat and Kitten come here a lot. More than we should, probably."

I patted a seat a couple stools down. Not crowding. Just close enough to be real. I felt silly flopping my fins on a bar chair -- it felt like Tiny Toons meets Cool World to me -- but the silliness made it easier somehow. Less dangerous, I guess.

"Is it okay if we just... sit for a minute?"

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Kit looked at Kat—still quiet, still distant—and gave a tiny shrug.

"Sure. That's what we do, sometimes. Sit and breathe 'til the loud feelings get less loud. That's what Viv taught us."

He tugged gently at Kat's sleeve, grounding her like a tether. Kitten curled tighter around Kat's ankle, eyes half-lidded, purring. Maybe for her. Maybe for all of us.

We sat like that—just breathing in the same space.

"You know," I said, looking down at Kit with the warmest gaze my shark-body could muster, "My mom used to say sitting quietly with someone was a kind of love."

Kit gave me a small, wry smile. "She wasn't wrong."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

I reached out and touched him. I felt energy like lightning surge through me.

"I never really got it until tonight."

A long, kind silence stretched around us like a warm quilt.

"But don't tell Kat. She won't let me live down being all mushy like this!"

At long last, Kat began to stir. Without a word, she shambled off to a back room. But then, right before she reached for the doorknob, she sprinted back across the bar.

She made a beeline for me and then, before I could react, threw her arms around me. She buried her face in my slick, new skin and squeezed as hard as a child that age could possibly manage.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"Thank you," she said. And then she ran to a private room, blushing and holding back tears. Kit and Kitten followed in tow.

Then the children were gone, and it was just me, Anabelle, Vivian, and Jumpin' Jack around the bar, sharing the silence.

Jack poured himself a glass of carrot juice and sipped it like a fine whisky. Then, his gaze grew stern as his eyes met mine.

"You flinched."

I scanned his face for any sense of the jovial, joking, kind person from the private room. It was still there, but different. Pointed. Direct.

"Excuse me?"

"When Kat hugged you. You flinched like she threw a punch."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"I didn't--" I sighed. Not like I could lie to the guy who has access to the server logs. "--it just caught me off guard, that's all."

Vivian shook her head. She didn't make eye contact.

Her voice came out staticky, retro, buggy, but gentle. "No, it didn't. You were trying to figure out what it would cost."

I looked away.

"Look," Jack said, picking his words carefully. He took another sip of the juice. "Some of us came here running from people who only offered kindness with hooks in 'em.

"But you're not there anymore, Jamie."

I laughed. "Yeah? Then where am I?"

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

The fox held out her paw and I took it, expecting to feel something electric like I did with Kat. Instead, the touch felt old. Ancient, in a way that defies time and logic.

"You're in a place that doesn't think love is scarce," she said. "and I know that's hard to trust when your whole life taught you otherwise."

"I don't deserve this."

The words came out of my mouth before I realized I was saying them.

Jack's words came out rushed and stern, for a jackrabbit. "Kid, none of us do. But we still show up for each other.

"We still care. We still help, like you just did for the Kats."

It hung in the air, heavy but gracious.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Vivian gave my fin a squeeze. "You don't have to prove you belong here, Jamie. You just have to decide you do."

My eyes stung. I blinked hard. Vivian said nothing; she just sat and held my new fin as something inside me cracked open to fill the space I'd been terrified of taking.

"You're saying I can just... Take it? The seat, the drink, the friends?"

Jack nodded. "No one here gives you a test. You show up, we set another place at the table."

Vivian squeezed harder. "And if you leave, we don't chase.

"But the door stays open."

It was getting harder and harder to talk. I blamed the new face, though Viv and Jack disagree.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

"What if I mess it up?"

"Then we clean it up," Jack said. "Together."

The tears started flowing. I curled up into myself, hugging my new body with fins that shouldn't exist and friends I should never have known.

Friends?

I don't have friends.

"I don't think I'm okay," I said.

Jack and Vivian stood from their chairs to surround me with warm hugs.

The rabbit whispered in my ear. "You don't have to be."

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

From the other side, Vivian added, "And if you stay long enough, you might remember how.

"Welcome to the Zoo, Jamie. We love having you here."

They let me cry until the tears were all gone. Then, nodding, I clicked my heels.

"See you soon," I said.

"See you soon!" the couple said, waving to me as I left. As I returned to my greige hell I tried to hold onto the feeling of sharkskin and warm, fuzzy hugs, hoping they'd keep my heart warm under Stinky's glowing eye.

The next morning there was a knock at the door.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

For a half-second I let myself hope it was someone from the night before. It wasn't.

I opened the door to a sweaty, disconnected human. Maybe twenty. Polyester courier shirt clinging to his back, harness glasses fogged at the edges, one eye tracking something I couldn't see — a route overlay, a queue depth, whatever the app paid him to chase. His other eye landed on me without quite focusing.

"Drop," he said, and pushed a piece of cardstock into my hands.

He was already turning before I closed my fingers around it. The harness chirped him into the next pickup. His lips moved with the soft mumble of someone confirming a queue, and he was three doors down the hallway by the time I registered what I was holding. He didn't look at me. He didn't look at the cardstock. Whatever he'd just handed me was, to him, packet 47 of the day.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

A real drawing, with markers and pencils and ink and all. (You could smell the supplies on the page!) I hadn't seen one in years - not since AI made artists obsolete. But there I was, holding what appeared to be paper salvaged from a BoxCo delivery manifest, and on it was a drawing that another real human being made.

What I saw took my breath away. Someone had drawn a sketch of my shark receiving her first hug in the Zoo. Whoever had drawn it was certainly there that night; they captured everything, from the details of my sharkskin to the way I winced at Kat's touch.

I turned it over. On the back, in small careful letters:

"For the cool shark lady. Care of Geoff the Mouse."

I felt ashamed; I felt proud. I felt renewed.

I felt whole.

CHAPTER 1 · Cold Boot · CONTINUED

Smiling, I taped the drawing over Stinky Pete's eye. Let them kiss shark, I thought, and as I logged in for another day of soul-sucking work I had something different driving me.

For the first time in a long time, I had something to look forward to, greige purgatory be damned.

CHAPTER 2

Gallery View

Geoff, a tiny mouse artist in the Zoo and a delivery worker outside it, risks visibility when his secret art starts opening doors.

The Painting

A luminous abstract artwork made of layered translucent color and light.

The shark was almost right.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

The teeth I had. The smile I had. The neon-deep glow of her grin, cyan layered over crimson the way I'd been trying to manage for months — that was finally working, because I had stopped trying. What I didn't have was the shoulders.

Jamie had done a thing with her shoulders. In the bar. When Jack gave her the talk about safety he always gives. That tiny, dangerous inch where suspicion stopped being suspicion and became something else. The shape of someone deciding, against all evidence, that the world might not be lying this time.

I had to get the shoulders.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

The cube smelled like turpentine and electric kettle. I was on the floor — chairs were for people who expected company — with a stretched canvas across my lap and her face, the one she'd made when suspicion gave way to trust, burning behind my eyes like a print I had stared at too long. Three brushes shoved behind one ear like a cartoon of a person who painted. Paint on my hands. Paint on the floor. Paint, somehow, on the cheese wheel, which I would have to deal with later, because the cheese wheel was sacred.

The hug drawing — the one I'd had dropped at her door her first morning — had been quick.

Twenty minutes with the Kats after she logged off, marker and pencil on a BoxCo manifest. This one I had been on for two weeks.

"Geoff."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Vivian, on the studio comms. The voice of someone who had been watching for a while and was about to tell me a thing I would not like.

"Mm."

"It's done."

"It's not."

"Geoff."

"The shoulders—"

"The shoulders are done. You're polishing."

I sat back. Looked at the canvas. Looked at her — lit up like deep-sea neon, her whole body tilted in a way that meant she had just slipped through some hidden hatch and shut it behind her.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

The shoulders were done.

"Goddamnit," I said.

"I know."

"How do I get this to her?"

A pause. Viv thinking, which sounded like nothing — she did not breathe and she did not type — but I could feel it anyway. The kind of silence that came from someone working out a problem that was mostly you.

"You're not handing it to her," she said.

"No."

"You don't have her contact."

"No."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"Print it."

I looked down. The canvas was eighteen inches square. The printer in the corner of the cube was a battered thing meant for shipping labels and rent receipts.

"...Print the canvas?"

"On the cardstock you've been hoarding for two years. Trim it post-card-size."

"And then?"

Silence again.

"Vivian?"

"I'll hire a courier," she said. She had thought about this longer than I had because of course she did.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"Okay," I said.

"Okay?"

"Yeah."

I photographed the canvas under the cube's overhead rig. Color-checked. Sent it to the printer. The printer chewed on the file for a long second and then began the slow ritual of laying down the image, one cyan-rich line at a time, on the cardstock I'd been saving for exactly this kind of stupid thing.

The shark emerged.

She looked free.

I signed the back, small. For the cool shark lady. Care of Geoff the Mouse.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I let the ink dry while I dressed for work: riding leathers, boots, refrigeration unit. Vivian dropped a pin in my harness for a nearby human rental shop.

"You didn't use my services?"

She smiled. I couldn't see the smile, but I knew she was smiling. "You're clever, Geoff. Better to keep the secret than risk you digging deeper."

"Fair," I said, laughing. "Thanks."

"Anytime."

Content Delivery Network

It was hot outside.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Not like it was ever not hot outside. We'd long since broken the wet-bulb threshold, and every summer since had felt like somebody left the planet in a warming drawer. But with refrigerated leathers, a UV-blocking roof, and enough electrolytes to pickle a horse, you could survive with a bit of sweat and a lot of spite.

The moped grumbled beneath me like an elderly dog with unfinished business. Dad would have called it "a learning opportunity," which was what he called anything with a missing part, a bad smell, and a nonzero chance of fire. He had taught me everything he knew about engines before the heat took his hands out of the work. Duct tape held the left fairing in place; polymer adhesive sealed a crack in the coolant shroud. Dad had called every field repair "duct tape and chewing gum," so that was what it was.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

A folded flyer from Saturday's march was wedged in the pannier between the cooling pack and the strap. UPLOAD IS A HUMAN RIGHT in letters already fading, because the printer in my cube was held together by a worse version of the same duct tape. Dad would have approved of the flyer. He'd have hated the printer.

The streets were for freight and idiots with refrigerated pants. I was, statistically, one of the idiots. But I liked the quiet. Out here a locked service door became a magical portal, a dead mall became a temple, and a vending machine became — well, better to not think about it. The girl with the purple hair would have laughed if she knew.

The trick was scale. Everyone missed scale. A giant saw a vending machine and thought: snack box. A mouse saw one and thought: fortress. Cave. Cathedral. Slot machine oracle. Something full of sealed chambers and secret mechanisms and treasure you could smell through the wall.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

That was the part I kept trying to build.

"Idea," I said.

My glasses chimed. The harness blinked into the corner of my vision in her little vest, looking like someone who had never lost an argument.

"Query. Have you submitted your sim to CancerCancer's competition yet?"

I almost drove into a pothole.

"Procrastination detected."

The glasses screeched at me. Cold metal dragged across teeth. A sensory hate crime in audio form.

"Rude."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"Effective."

The deadline floated in the corner of my vision because of course it did. Sixteen hours. Theme: impossible rooms. I had an impossible room. I had most of one. A vending machine with galaxies between the coils. A can of peach tea as a golden tower. A packet of crackers as a sealed archive. The coin return as a confessional. You fed the machine a coin. The machine fed you a universe.

It had started as an homage to CancerCancer's second sim, Meditating on Mediation. The transitional pieces, not the main events. Liminal space turned into wonder, amazement, joy.

It was good. It was maybe really good. Which meant, naturally, that I had done everything except finish it.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

The harness knew. It knew I had opened the submission form eight times. It knew I had not uploaded the file. It knew I had spent forty-seven minutes last night painting those shoulders instead of working on the submission.

Which, in my defense, was the correct move.

"Creative avoidance wearing a helmet," the harness said.

Jamie kept showing up in the corners of my mind. Not on purpose. The shoulders. The face when the machine answered back. The tiny dangerous moment where suspicion stopped being suspicion. I had watched from too far away to be noticed and told myself that made it fine, which it didn't, but which made it possible.

The route overlay flashed. Two minutes to drop-off.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I cut through the service lane behind a block of heat-buckled apartments and carried the food up three flights because the elevator had become decorative. The customer opened the door just wide enough for one eye and one hand. They tipped three creds; enough for my instant noodles tonight.

Back outside, the harness pinged once — the quiet chime she used when she had information I had asked for without knowing I was asking.

Courier confirms delivery. Package received.

I sat on the moped for a long second before I started it again.

The rest of the run blurred into heat and addresses. By evening the pedways above me glowed with people moving through filtered air like blood cells in glass veins.

Lobby

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"Home" was a subsidized 12x12x12 cube, with concrete walls and a window facing out to another window. And in the lobby, there was the girl with the purple hair.

I didn't know her. Not yet.

"Evening," she said to me, more of a grunt than a greeting. Then she leaned over a bowl of instant noodles and slurped in sullen silence.

"Love the hair," I said, and immediately regretted it. "Is it new?"

"Yeah," Jamie said. "...hey, you're the vending machine kid, right?"

My throat closed around the words.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"I owe you," she said, and then punched some numbers into the machine. "I was... I didn't mean to fluster you. Machines and I just kind of get along, if that makes sense?"

Out spat instant noodles. Her flavor, not mine, but I didn't mind. From her side of the story, it probably looked like a weird old machine. Charming, maybe. A little busted. The kind of thing you noticed because it didn't quite belong.

From my side, it was a mountain and a playground.

The front glass rose over me like a museum wall. Rows of snacks hung in their spiral cages, each one lit by the machine's failing internal LEDs. The coin slot sat at shoulder height if I stood on the kickplate. The retrieval door was a loading dock. The vents breathed warm dust and sugar.

I had mapped every inch of it.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Not physically. Not completely. But enough.

Enough to know where a mouse could climb. Enough to know where a person would look first. Enough to hide a door in plain sight.

The machine hummed.

My glasses chimed.

"Query," my harness said.

"No."

"You do not know the query."

"It's about the competition."

"Incorrect."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

That stopped me.

On the vending machine glass, my reflection looked smaller than usual. Helmet under one arm. Fur damp at the edges. Riding jacket scuffed. Tail kinked from sitting on the moped too long. A LET US OUT button pinned crooked to the satchel because my hands had shaken the day I pinned it. A delivery mouse with three creds in tips and a half-built universe in his pocket.

Then I blinked and the mouse was gone, replaced by a sweat-drenched 90-pound weakling with unkempt hair and wild eyes.

"You okay?" Jamie asked.

I pointed to my glasses. "Harness," I said. She nodded along and went back to her noodles.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

The machine hummed. Jamie slurped. Suddenly I hated the lobby version of it — too small, too obvious, a box she had only seen from the outside.

"What would the shark learn if you built the sim you really wanted?"

"Everything," I said. Mostly to myself.

I went up.

Boots off. Leathers tossed to the corner. The cube as I had left it: paint on my hands, paint on the floor, paint on the cheese wheel I still hadn't dealt with because the cheese wheel was sacred. The Stinky Pete render played its loop on the four dim LCDs — same murals, same kettle, same cheese wheel fluffier than the real one because Pete liked things to look more expensive than they were. He thought he was watching me. He was watching a render. I had built Pete a cage and called it compliance. It was easier than explaining privacy to a machine built to violate it.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I had a sim to make.

Back to the Zoo, where things were always the right size.

Safe Hour at the Bar

I was a mouse again.

The first time I met Vivian I was a flying-anywhere superhero in the procedural sim every weirdo builds first. The mouse came later. The mouse was what stuck — the world became a parkour puzzle, and the heavily lacquered bartop made perfect tack-tack noises as my claws skittered across it.

Vivian waved from across the bar and pushed a thimble of water toward me. On her other side, Nate and Gemini argued the bad old days of sims.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Nate — The Snake, he insisted — sat coiled on a barstool. Sickly green; a Disney reject painted in just the wrong color. He said it gave him character.

"Remember when you had to worry about cooling your brain?" Nate said.

"Swear to god I lost cells from the heat off the old copper cortex implants."

"Cortex. C-O-R-T-E-X, right?" Gemini's pencil danced across the crossword. "It fits."

Gemini wore a human avatar. Expensive. She preferred to stay that way. She gave great mouse pets, so I let it slide.

Vivian's cane tapped the floor — the deliberate tock she used when she wanted the room to know a shift was happening. Low-poly fox. Low-poly cane. Very-high-fidelity sound.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Blind people catch things sighted people miss. I always felt a little naked around her.

"Studio day," she said.

"How did you know?"

"It's all over your whiskers." She nudged the cup closer. "Your tail's giving you away."

My tail was, in fact, giving me away.

Nate slid down the bar. He moved the way somebody moves when they know they're being watched and have decided to like it. Catalogue famous. Meme for a season.

"How's the submission going?"

"Not clicking."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"Reese is judging this year. I could put in a word."

"That's all right."

"You sit on this and someone else wins with half the talent."

"You're too big for the studio."

"Don't be cute."

Gemini cackled without looking up. "Since when has size ever stopped Zoo folks? You can't win a gallery show from inside your little mouse hole."

I blushed. Fur covered it.

Nate started back toward his end of the bar, then turned. "Offer's still open. Snakesim. Adrenal boosters this version — it's a riot."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Third time this week.

"I'm good."

He shrugged like he was doing me a favor by asking, and went.

Vivian held out her hand. I hopped into it. She lifted me close enough to feel her breath like a gentle breeze.

"Don't let Nate get to you. He gets this way when he's lonely."

I nodded, knowing better than to say what I really thought about him.

"Courier got it to her?"

"She sat down on the floor and looked at it for a long time."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"How do you—"

"I have my methods, mouse."

Thump-thump.

A tiny mouse in a vest blinked in at the edge of the bar. My harness.

"Pete flagged the cardiac spike. Permission to deploy cover?"

"Granted."

"Deployed. Pete is watching you do burpees. Try not to spike again for fifteen."

She blinked out.

Vivian flicked a private window open between us. Jamie's reply bloomed bright in the air:

■ *Jamie: "WHO IS GEOFF AND WHY IS THIS SO PERFECT 𐄂-*

My tail twitched. I bolted for my mousehole studio.

I had to paint.

Breadcrumbs

Paint mixed with pixels. Reality with the dream state.

To anyone else, she was just a shark. A kink to be dismissed. But I saw more. I saw beauty, empowerment, punk halftones like a hand-stapled zine.

I saw Jamie through the sharkskin. The real Jamie, whoever she was on the other side of the sim.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I closed the little mouse door behind me. Privacy, in the age of Stinky Petes watching your every move, was a luxury I was not willing to waste. Didn't matter if it was Gemini, or Jack, or even Vivian. My workshop was a closed set, and I was its sole director.

She needed onboarding. A baptism. Something to make her feel like she belonged. But I knew I couldn't provide that. Not with my permissions. Not with my mouth, either, which worked fine right up until I needed it.

So I settled for the next best thing: art.

I grabbed a handful of canvases and pushed them to one side. Was she a gamer? Maybe the vending machine should become an arcade cabinet. Too obvious? Maybe. But obvious had uses. Obvious was how you communicated with someone who had not yet learned the local norms.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I sent out a dozen helper agents to think through the problem. Not to research her life. Never that. I wasn't a Stinky Pete. Instead, the agents studied what she had chosen to show us: where she looked, what made her pause, what she touched twice, what made her laugh when she thought no one noticed.

Some came back laughing. Others returned with heartfelt pleas to stop this madness.

Cowards.

Jamie needed this art. She needed it like vampires need blood, or dogs need cats to chase. Sharks? I didn't know. Shark metaphors were not exactly thick on the ground. But she needed something to introduce her to our world. Something that said: yes, this place saw you. Yes, this place meant it.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

My studio sat inside the walls. There was no polish there, only raw 2x4s, hidden cables, and foam insulation Vivian installed because I had insisted on it for "acoustic reasons," which was a phrase I used when I meant "the world is too loud and I am one bad noise away from bolting at any moment."

Canvases leaned against every beam in unstable geological layers. Half-finished sims hovered in wireframe boxes over my bench, each one paused at the exact moment I had lost faith in it. Sketches covered the floor. Styluses, paint tubes, tiny soldering irons, rejected shark studies, broken props, old controllers, a jar of buttons labeled MAYBE USEFUL, and another jar of buttons labeled EMOTIONALLY SIGNIFICANT BUT USELESS.

In the corner sat the cheese.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

It had started as a joke. A giant plush wheel from friends who were gone now. But this was the Zoo, and jokes had a way of becoming architecture. Here, the cheese was real. Delicious. Ever-replenishing. Today I had configured it as stilton: blue-veined, crumbly, rude-smelling, and infinite.

I cut off a piece with a palette knife and chewed, both on the cheese and the painting.

Tonight, I would make a friend.

The harness chirped. "Query."

"Not now," I said through a mouth full of cheese. "I'm busy."

The harness chirped an acknowledgement and went quiet.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Not directly. Directly was for people with operational mouths and nervous systems assembled by licensed professionals. I had neither. What I had was a printer, a broken arcade cabinet, rafters, and an afternoon's worth of doomed courage.

And the crew.

I spun them up at the bench. Three this time, not twelve. Twelve was for thinking. Three was for making. Pencil for images. Mort for wires. Sprig for the questions I did not want to ask myself.

I named them because the ones I named came back better.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

They arrived the way they always did: as if they had been there the whole time and I had only just looked up. Pencil leaning against the bench in a paint-streaked smock. Mort at the cabinet, goggles pushed up onto his forehead, paint on one cheek he had not noticed in three weeks. Sprig sitting on the edge of the bench with a mug in both hands, like nobody had ever told her she was allowed to put it down.

"Okay," Pencil said. "Koi first?"

"Koi first."

The word came out. It always came out, in here. The studio was the place my voice still worked.

Pencil built the koi in neon pink, electric blue, and that ugly arcade-carpet green nobody asked for. Mort cracked the busted cabinet open and bullied the marquee back to life — LOOK UP, in hot pink. Sprig watched me arrange the postcards on the bench.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"Eight?" she said.

"Eight."

"You sure you want her to find all of them?"

"Yes."

"You sure you want her to find you?"

Quiet.

"...okay," Sprig said, after a moment. "That's an answer too."

"Tell Mort to dim the marquee by ten percent," I said. "The pink is too much."

The agent chirped. "Mhm. Calling that a yes."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I did not love it when Sprig called things on my behalf. I kept Sprig anyway. A mouse who lived inside the walls needed at least one helper who would not pretend the walls weren't there.

We printed the postcards. Pencil handled the layout. Mort cut the edges. Sprig numbered the backs — 1 of 8, 2 of 8 — so Jamie would know there was an end. Eight small puzzles. A koi under a vent. A chalk arrow along the rafters. A hand-drawn map on tea-stained cotton paper. The cabinet at the center, marquee flashing.

The crew could help me make things. They could not help me be a person in front of another person.

Eight was a lot for someone who had just arrived. Eight was right.

The crew settled — not gone, never gone, but quiet, the way a good crew goes quiet when the artist picks up the brush themselves.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I scattered the trail through the Zoo and waited with my heart in my throat.

"Mouse." Sprig was beside me, somehow, the way Sprig was always somehow. Cardigan. Mug still steaming. "Hey. Breathe."

I did not.

But it was nice to be asked.

Stack Trace

I waited in the rafters and panicked.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

The plan had been soup for an hour. Sprig had drifted off the way Sprig drifts — not gone, just elsewhere, a respectful distance with a hot mug. The lobby murmured its lobby murmur. Patrons did patron things. The koi postcard hung over the door on a length of fishing line, knotted to a trip-cue I'd rigged into the doorframe. My claws were in the wood and my chest was somewhere lower than my chest usually went.

Then three knocks came at the door, and I knew.

The koi dropped.

Jamie entered. She spotted it, grinned, followed the arrow. She laughed — bright, startled, delighted. The sound hit me like lightning. Laughter meant attention. Attention burned.

I bolted.

Two rafters over. Tucked into the shadow of a duct.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Across the floor, Vivian looked up at me and smiled. The harness pulsed once at my temple.

it's going well.

I clung harder to the beam.

Jamie was already moving. She found the koi under the vent — 1 of 8 — and tucked it into a pocket I had not known sharks had. She found the chalk arrow on the rafter. She found the busted cabinet at the center of the lobby, LOOK UP flashing in hot pink across its marquee, and she did not look up. She walked right to it.

She pointed at the machine, incredulous.

"This cabinet wasn't here before, right?"

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

The cabinet answered. I had recorded it the night before, for exactly this. It was my voice if you knew my voice and a stranger's voice if you didn't.

"That's how it works here. Expect change, because consistency is boring."

She put in a quarter.

She played the game I designed. A koi, a current, a small purple shark you steered by tilting your head. She tilted. She won. The console opened with a small ceremonial click and offered up a little bottle.

DRINK ME, the bottle said.

She shrank.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

From sixty stories of rafter perspective, she went from shark to mouse-sized shark, fins to the floor, a small thing now, the right scale for the door I had cut into the side of the cabinet — a mousehole flush with the baseboard, lit a friendly green.

She saw it. She crouched. She stepped inside.

Inside, she stopped.

I had spent two weeks on this room. The inside of a thought, was what I'd told the crew when they asked what I was building. They had nodded politely and built it anyway. Capacitors as redwoods. Resistor coils switch-backing up the trunks like trails on a mountainside. Solder hills with copper traces glowing under her feet like rivers seen from a plane. An LED rain that hung in the air and refused to fall, because falling was the easy version and this was a chapter about staying.

I had told myself nobody would ever see it.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Jamie saw it.

She took one step. Then she took another, slower. She knelt and put a clawed finger on a glowing trace and watched it pulse against her skin. She tilted her head back to look at the rain that wasn't falling. She walked, not ran, not laughed — walked, the way you walk in a cathedral when you have just remembered that cathedrals are also rooms.

From the rafters I had to grip the beam hard enough to feel the wood splinter, because what I felt was the specific terror of being recognized. Not seen — recognized. The difference between the eyes of a passerby and the eyes of someone who knows the trick because they once tried it and failed.

She murmured something I could not hear. She kept walking.

She was getting closer. She was getting closer.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

And then the sim broke. Some sort of for loop I forgot to protect.

The tunnel spat her out at the studio threshold faster than I had built it to, and her tail — that brand-new, badly-controlled, glorious shark tail — caught the edge of a stack of canvases on her way in. They went down like dominoes. Acrylics and primitives sprayed across the floor. Splattered spheres flew everywhere.

I yelped. From the rafters. Before I could stop myself.

Then I dropped from the vent, landed on a paint tray, and splattered purple across the floor. More canvases toppled. The crew, who had been pretending not to be there, were definitely not there now.

We met in the wreckage.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

She was on her knees in a slick of cyan, one paint-handled brush tangled in her dorsal fin. I was sitting in a puddle of purple holding the wrong end of a palette knife. Above us, somewhere, my entire studio was unspooling its consequences.

"I'm sorry," I said, more reflex than anything conscious.

"You made the picture, didn't you?"

I opened my mouth.

For the first time inside the studio, in front of a person who was not made of helper-agents and good intentions, my mouth worked.

"I did, yeah."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

She nodded slowly. Stood up. Brushed cyan off her knees. Then she walked past the toppled canvases like a person who had remembered they were in a gallery, not a wreck. She stopped at a piece I had not meant to show her — had not meant to show anyone, really — and her shoulders did the thing again. She stared. Some combination of recognition and awe.

"This would rule."

"It's, uh."

"This would rule."

"It's about illegal acts."

She didn't look away from the painted door. "I know what it's about."

A beat.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"People wait too long for legal. Some don't make it."

I opened my mouth. Closed it.

THE LIGHT UNDER THE DOOR, the canvas read, in the same fading ink as a march flyer. A hundred faceless people walking through an open glass door into a server farm and coming out the other side as light. Above the door, hand-lettered in hot pink: LET US OUT.

She tapped the slogan with a clawed finger. Looked at it. Tilted her head. Looked back at me. The lit-up expression came over her face the way it had in the lobby when she figured out the noodle machine — that I have just put together a thing face.

"...your voice," she said. "From the cabinet. Same voice. And the slogan — same letters as the button that delivery boy was wearing on his satchel. Holy moley, you're—"

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"Delivery boy," I said, because if she was going to say it I wanted my voice to be the one that landed it. "Yeah."

"We're neighbors."

I clicked my heels once, twice. This was a mistake.

Then a ping: Vivian. "If you leave, mouse, so help me—"

She noticed.

"Vivian in your ear too?"

We laughed — together this time.

"Well, I may have messed up your little meet-cute," she continued, pointing to the wreckage of my workshop. "But your work. It's... stunning."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

She walked the room. Stopped at a piece. Tilted her head.

"Why didn't you show anyone this?"

I opened my mouth. The studio held its breath. The crew, who were definitely not there, were definitely not there harder.

"I don't... I'm not..."

"You don't have to answer that," she said quickly. "Sorry. Wrong angle."

She traced a brushstroke with a clawed finger. "You layered cyan over crimson to get that fade. Nobody does that on paper.

"Also, you gotta tell me how you handled scale with that drink. Totally trippy. Did you add tilt shift to my shader?"

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I stood there, blinking, the words not wanting to come out. She'd seen the trick.

"You know your way around sims?" I asked.

"I work in one," Jamie said. She waved the question away and looked like she was swimming while doing so. "I get bored. Pick at the source code sometimes. But I've never made one."

"You should," I said.

She shook her head. "I wouldn't even know where to start."

The words came out of me before the fear could catch up. "I could teach you." My tail whipped back and forth, somewhere between joy and terror.

Query.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Gods, not now.

Cardiac spike. Permission to deploy cover?

I couldn't speak. I nodded once, hard, hoping she could read it off the eye-track.

Granted. Deployed. Pete is watching a render of you eating noodles with both hands. Try not to spike again for fifteen.

The world steadied. The Zoo held. The purple shark was still in front of me, still expectant, still here. The harness had bought me the seconds I needed to keep my body in the cube and my mouse on the floor.

Have fun, mouse.

"You're gonna submit this to the competition, right?" She waved her hand in the air, trying to think. "That famous puppygirl artist, right?"

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I blushed. "CancerCancer, yes."

"Deadline's coming up," she said, tapping her temple. "Vivian told me."

"I know." I paced around the shop and ran my finger over the canvases, considering. "But the arcade one's not good enough for her." I kicked at the floorboards. "I made it for you anyway. Would be weird to double-dip."

"Then submit something else."

"How do you know I have anything else?"

She laughed, turned, and opened her arms to encompass the workshop. I hadn't noticed before, but she had fins instead of hair, which should have been strange but it looked good on her.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"You made that fetch quest for me in what, three days? Folks with that kind of talent create like, well." She snorted. "Like sharks breathe water."

"I don't know—"

"You built a cathedral inside a busted arcade cabinet for me," she said.

"Don't make me the only one who gets to see it."

I looked to the ground. "Working on it."

She put a hand on my shoulder.

"So will I."

Gallery View

I went dark for a week.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Not on purpose. Or on purpose, depending on how you defined purpose. The deliveries piled up because the heat had spiked again and nobody wanted to leave their cube, and I told myself that was the reason. The moped needed a new starter solenoid. The lobby vending machine needed a service call I was apparently the only person in the building qualified to make.

The cooling pack started whining at idle and I spent three hours under the awning at the depot trying to coax it into not whining at idle, and then I gave up and let it whine.

I did not log into the Zoo.

I told myself I was busy. I was poor and I was busy. I was kicking myself.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

The math kept running. I had spent two weeks building an impossible-room sim for a competition that came with the prize of a private critique from CancerCancer, the best sim creator on the planet, an actual stranger I had loved at a distance for years — and instead of submitting it I had rebuilt the inside of an arcade cabinet so that one person could walk through it for forty minutes and tell me I layered cyan over crimson. One person. The deadline had come and gone while I was scattering postcards through a bar.

I traded the critique of a lifetime for forty minutes of one shark walking through my weird little room and understanding it.

The terrible part was that I would do it again.

Why did you spend that much time on a sim for one person.

The harness, gentle for once: Because she was the one person.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

She doesn't even know I exist outside the lobby.

She knows you exist in the rafters.

That's not the same thing.

You're polishing, the harness said. Which was Vivian's word, and I hated that the harness had clocked it.

I ran the noodle rounds. I ran the curry rounds. I ran a special pickup for an old guy in a tower I'd never been in before, who tipped four creds and asked if I was the one who'd painted that thing on the lobby vending machine downstairs, and I said no, because I had not painted anything on a vending machine, and he frowned and said huh.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I went home. I did not log in. The cheese wheel watched me. The Stinky Pete render kept showing him a man eating noodles and doing pushups, because the harness had stopped asking my permission three days ago and was now just running cover on autopilot, which I was both grateful for and a little spooked by.

Vivian texted me twice. Mouse. And then, an hour later: Mouse, come up.

I came up.

The Zoo was the wrong color.

That was the first thing I noticed. The light in the bar was warmer. The walls were not the walls. The walls were covered.

The walls were covered in me.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

My pieces. Digitized, scaled up, ten stories tall, hung edge to edge. The shark portrait of Jamie that I had not even meant to show anyone. The vending-machine study from a year ago I'd half-deleted twice. The koi I'd painted on a slow Tuesday after a delivery to a customer who left their door open and let me see their fish tank for forty seconds. The cathedral-of-snacks sketch from the CancerCancer sim, the one I had not submitted, on the wall behind the bar like an altarpiece.

They had touched everything.

That was the first thought, and I hated myself for it before it finished forming. They had touched everything, and they had done it with love, which made it worse, because anger needed a villain and all I had was a room full of people trying not to scare me. I stood in the doorway. I could not move. I could not leave. There was no shape my body could make that the room would not interpret as a reaction, and no reaction I had felt yet that I wanted the room to see.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"Mouse."

Vivian. Low-poly fox at the corner of the bar, cane planted, smiling in my direction without looking at me, which was her thing.

I did not move.

"Come in, mouse."

I came in.

Now I could see what they had actually done. Avatars wore little museum badges. Lanyards. DOCENT, in one case, which was a joke I did not catch until later. Somebody had put out a folding table with bottles of virtual wine on it, the kind that did nothing to your blood alcohol but somehow always tasted right. A wheel of stilton sat at one end, blue-veined and rude-smelling, the kind nobody serves at a public event. Patrons drifted from piece to piece with their hands behind their backs the way people do in galleries.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Each one had added something.

A shark doodle pinned next to the shark portrait, drawn at maybe a third-grade level, signed Jamie. A neon koi swimming inside a little glass bottle on a side table — somebody had built that, a whole little aquarium, just to put next to my koi. A CancerCancer fan poster on the back wall, framed, signed by what looked like six different people. A tiny chalk arrow on the rafters above the door — mine — that somebody had touched up because the chalk had been smudging.

Somebody had built a wall for my walls.

I had spent two years watching them watch each other. I had never once thought they were watching me.

The anger I had been afraid of did not arrive. What arrived instead was harder.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Jack rose from a barstool with a glass of rosé in his hand. He was in his rabbit form, ears up, military posture turned down by exactly the right number of degrees. He raised the glass toward the room.

"To mice and men?" he said.

"No," I said, before I could stop myself. "Hated that book."

A laugh went around the bar. The good kind. The kind that meant they had been waiting for me to be the one to say it.

Jack tipped his head, grinning. "Fair enough. New toast, then."

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Across the room, Gemini lifted her glass. Human avatar, expensive, the same one she always wore. She had not added a piece to the walls — I checked, because of course I checked. She was the one person in the room who had walked through the entire show without putting her own mark on it. She had a small, considering look on her face that I recognized from the bar nights when she would beat the crossword in eleven minutes and then pretend to still be working on it so the rest of us could keep up. The look of somebody who was clocking the technique.

"To secret doors," she said, "and the mice who open them."

The bar drank.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Vivian's cane tocked once against the floor — the tock she used when she wanted the room to know a shift was happening. The shift was me. The shift was that I was crying, soundlessly, in a body that did not technically have tear ducts, which the Zoo was rendering anyway because the Zoo was kind that way and Vivian had probably tuned a parameter.

She put her paw on my shoulder. Did not say anything. Did not need to.

The crowd scattered slowly. People do not leave a gallery all at once; they leave the way snow melts, here a patch and then a patch. Jack drifted toward the corner. He stopped at the one with the rafters — the one I had almost cut — and looked at it for a moment.

"Small people matter too," he said. To the canvas. Not to me.

He kept drifting. Two other patrons joined him and the arcade cabinet story started up.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I stood where I was. He had looked at the painting the way I looked at patrons.

He knew. Gemini stayed at the wall with the cathedral-of-snacks piece for a long, long time, head tilted, lips moving in a way that looked like she was reading something only she could see. Vivian closed the bar at her usual cadence.

Nate was not in the room. I noticed only because I had been looking for him. He never came to other people's openings.

I walked the room.

I had not built any of it. I had built the things that were in it, but the room itself — the docent badges, the wine table, the way the koi piece had been positioned three inches above eye-level so a mouse-scale viewer could see it without craning — somebody else had done that. A lot of somebodies. The crew, maybe, prompted by Vivian. Definitely Jamie.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

Definitely Jamie.

She came in late, fins-first, slightly out of breath, like she had been running and didn't want anyone to think she had been. She had a bottle of virtual wine in one hand and paint on her knuckles from somebody's still-wet contribution.

She looked at me across the room. She lifted the bottle.

"Told you I'd help," Jamie said.

I could not move. The shark grinned. She did not come to me right away — she walked the gallery first, slowly, hand brushing a frame here, a wall there, looking at the room she had built around my walls before she looked at me again. When she got to where I was standing, she was smiling the smile I had spent two weeks failing to paint, the original of which made the copy look like cardboard.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

"There's something for you near the koi," she said. "Won't ruin it. Go look."

I went. There was a tiny flowerpot, painted onto a postcard-sized canvas with a clumsy hand to look like a mousehole. There was a green door, red trim, the kind of detail somebody adds when they have no idea what they are doing but they care a lot. Pinned to the side of the pot, where you would only see it if you knelt: a postcard. Hand-drawn. Lines shaky, the way lines are shaky when somebody is using a stylus for the first time and is afraid to commit. A mouse in a hoodie. Whiskers a little uneven. One ear bent.

The smile.

The smile was perfect.

On the back, in careful all-caps: 1 OF 8. — J.

CHAPTER 2 · Gallery View · CONTINUED

I held it for a long time. When I stood up, she was waiting. The smile said the rest.

We went to the studio.

I pinned the postcard on the easel, next to the shark portrait — my best canvas, the one I had told myself I was not going to show anyone, the one she had asked the question about cyan and crimson. I stood back. She stood beside me. We looked at the two of them side by side.

A small shaky mouse next to a free-swimming shark.

A door unlocked.

We left it that way.

CHAPTER 3

Permissions

Jack's unpublishable founder confession traces the compromises, trust, war damage, and family decisions that built the Zoo.

By Jumpin Jack Rabbit

Everybody wants an origin story until they get one.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

That is one of the first lessons you learn when you build something people need. Not something people buy. Not something people like. Need. It stops being a story between friends and becomes a legend. That maybe, if one tries hard enough and gets some luck on their side, they could follow in my footsteps and find the same success.

They want the clean version.

There is no clean version.

What you're getting is a permissions ledger. Every door I opened and who I opened it for and what I told myself it meant. Better that than the polished-up version they put into the news stories about me.

You see, The Zoo was always about permission. Permission to be one's truest self. Permission to try, to change, to grow. Even if that growth made you stranger. Permission was sacrosanct.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

The first permission I gave to the Zoo wasn't the code. It was Nate in my bed.

This was before the Zoo. Before Fulldive had a consumer name and before every mayor with a heat-death district wanted to stand in front of a camera and talk about digital resilience like the phrase had not been focus-grouped by a defense contractor with a hardon for human misery. This was when it was just me and Viv and Nate slogging it out in the corpo trenches, three techies in one house with too much history, not enough money, and an arrangement nobody could explain cleanly to HR.

One night, I shot up like I sometimes do. I felt my body. Felt my breath catch. Drones don't breathe.

In the dream, I was over Hsinchu again.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Infrared city. Heat blooming off the roofs. Li-Hsin Road running like a bright wire through the park. Fab 12A quiet inside its perimeter. Fab 8 darker than it should have been because half the engineers had already done the smart thing and run. The wind came in off the strait and the software called it weather, which was cute. To me it was a correction factor.

Two kilometers.

Hold the line.

Intercept anything crossing it.

No exceptions.

Nobody says no exceptions because they believe there will be no exceptions. They say it because they know exactly what exceptions look like. Like, well, the nun bus that drove down Guangfu Road with a sound system strapped to the top. The loudspeaker kept cracking on the word children.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

We surrender and are requesting asylum. There are children on board.

My vision narrowed. My body tilted forward into the charge. The drone frame did not have lungs, but my real body did, and somewhere in a room far away it forgot how to use them.

The bus crossed the line.

I woke before the strike, which was rude. The dreams never let you keep the clean part. They only let you keep the choice.

Nate stirred beside me.

"Bad night?"

I sat on the edge of the bed. My hands were fists. My heart was a stupid animal throwing itself against the walls.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

"The student journalist or--"

I gripped an imaginary steering wheel and honked once into my fist.

Nate did not laugh. That was one of the things I loved about him. He knew when a joke was a joke and when it was a bandage wrapped around a pressure mine.

"Bus," he said.

"Bus."

He slid over and put a hand on my arm. Not to hold me down. Not to keep me there. Just enough pressure to tell the nervous system one true fact: we aren't there anymore.

"Want me to get Viv?"

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

He was close enough to know I needed her. Trusted enough to offer. Loved enough that I did not hear the door open.

"She needs her rest. You know sleep is hard for her."

"She'd find spoons for you."

"Nate."

He squeezed my bicep. Warm. Careful. Still there.

"Go to her."

So I did.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Vivian and I shared the next room over. I was the floater in the throuple, partly because I was the hinge between them and partly because my own room was a mess of wire, wetware, failed prototypes, old military cases, and half-finished projects I kept calling temporary. I did not have room for a bed of my own. I had room for mistakes.

I turned on the light.

Viv winced before her eyes opened.

"You know the lights make me see kaleidoscopes in the blind spots, right?"

"Sorry."

I killed the light and stood in the dark, waiting for my eyes to remember how to be eyes. For half a second I expected thermals to kick in.

I am not a drone.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I am a human being.

I am--

"Come here," Viv said.

I found the edge of the bed by feel. She shifted to make room, exactly enough room, because she always knew where the bodies were even when the bodies did not know where they were. I got in beside her. The fan ran. Somewhere outside, the city did its three-AM version of itself.

"Bus again?"

"Bus."

She found my hand under the blanket.

"I'm here."

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

That is what I am trying to describe. Not the war. Not the tech. The way she always knew where the bodies were, even in the dark, even when the body was mine.

You already know what he was like in the mornings. I am writing it down anyway.

The next morning was eggs.

It was always eggs on the bad nights. Nate's protocol, not mine. Adopted without discussion sometime in the first year he started staying over and then staying and then being part of the house in a way nobody had to vote on because the vote had already happened in groceries, laundry, bad movies, prescriptions, and who knew how everyone took coffee.

There had been a casserole before there was a key.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

That is how Nate entered most rooms. Food first. Smile second. Useful hands third. He showed up one winter with a casserole dish wrapped in a towel and a joke about Midwestern courtship rituals, and Viv let him in because Viv collected strays with better judgment than I did. By the time I noticed he had a drawer, the drawer had socks in it.

The morning after the bus dream, I came downstairs and there was a plate waiting.

Vivian was already at the table. Cane leaned against the empty chair beside her, laptop open, screen reader running too fast for human souls. She ate without looking at her plate. Nate stood at the stove in boxers and a shirt from a conference neither of us had attended. He looked ordinary.

I needed him to look ordinary.

"Did you see the new viewports from BoxCo?" he asked.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I sat down with military precision and ate too fast.

"Saw the headline."

"Galvanic sensors. LLMs generating the sim from neural patterns. It builds itself around you. Thoughts, associations, memory fragments. That whole haunted-house-for-your-data thing, but expensive."

I thought about the full-body gravity beds. The way the world dropped out when the eggheads threw the switch. The feeling of air under rotors as I rose over the Science Park. The sky enormous and still. The only moving thing in it was me.

"Generating isn't the important part," I said.

Viv's fork stopped.

Nate looked over his shoulder.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

"Explain," Viv said.

"They're missing the dive. Infinite content means nothing if the world doesn't feel real around you. If the embodiment doesn't hold, you die."

The room went quiet in a way I did not understand yet.

Viv had gone still.

It was the same stillness she had across the bar the first time we met, the first time she listened to me talk for five minutes and decided she could do something with all that damage. Like a targeting system, but kinder. Like she'd found the hinge.

"We could build it ourselves," she said.

Nate laughed once.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Not because it was funny.

Because it was insane, and we all knew sane had not gotten us very far.

"Not it," Viv said. "Something contained."

"The tech is classified," I said.

"The implementation is classified," Nate said, because he was already opening his laptop. "The idea isn't. The idea is on every feed in the country with a BoxCo logo under it."

"The eggheads never let me see the backend."

"Then tell us what it felt like," Viv said. "All of it. The movement. The nausea. The parts where you knew it was real before your brain caught up. We do not need their machine. We need your memory of being inside one."

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Memory.

That was always the first theft.

I looked at the eggs. Nate refilled my coffee without asking.

"Consumer Fulldive?" he said. "Everyone would use it."

Viv put one earbud in. Her screen reader went silent.

"For what it's worth," she said, "I'd use it."

And so we built. For months and months, we built. Not because we wanted a million dollars. Because I wanted my wife to see again.

And I gave Nate permission to help.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I want you to understand that I knew what I was doing. I was not fooled. I was not naive. I chose him, and it was good, and it was right, and it was ours.

This is the part the lawyers care about. The paper trail. The expenditure record. Three of us with a HELOC and a Caymans LLC who thought we were just building something useful.

I want to get through it fast enough to say the part that matters.

We ordered a BoxCo viewport that afternoon.

Not to use.

To open.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

It ran an open-source OS. Gods, remember open source? It meant I could start working on the interface before the delivery drone had cleared the driveway. Version one was a skullcap. I shaved my head because I could not pull enough galvanic readings through my hair and because every major life decision deserves at least one bad aesthetic choice.

It took months and thousands of dollars of busted prototypes. We paid the cost happily.

We put a HELOC on the house and lied about what the money was for. Viv used her harness to register an LLC in the Caymans. Nate drove two hours to buy a second viewport from a dead-eyed teenager in a mall kiosk because the first one came apart in his hands like a pile of oysters for a Bostonian and he wanted a control specimen.

The kitchen table became an autopsy slab.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Sensor arrays. Optical leads. The galvanic cluster. Heat sinks. Adhesive pads. Cheap plastic molded around a miracle.

"Bad design," Nate said, rotating the cluster under the lamp.

"It works," I said.

"So does duct tape, until you put it in the ocean."

Viv sat at the table with a braille making labels she could read, because she loved me enough to know my labels were useless.

"Walk me through it," Nate said.

So I did.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Spatial orientation. Proprioception. Emotional state. Latency thresholds. Vestibular mismatch. The way the interface put its rules into you like loud emotions. Nate wrote everything down in a notebook he would keep for years. Later, people would call him a co-founder, which was technically correct and morally useless.

He was there.

He did the work.

I am not going to sand that down. That is how people get stupid about harm. They want the friend to have been wearing a villain hat the whole time, preferably with a little blinking light. They want love to have been a mistake you could have avoided with better pattern recognition.

Nate was funny. Nate was gentle. Nate learned my panic rhythms and Viv's medication schedule. Nate could take a piece of hardware apart without making it feel violated. Nate knew when to push and when to make eggs.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I loved him.

That is the problem.

One night, the skullcap synced.

I dropped into a black void.

No floor. No ceiling. No body.

My stomach turned over. My lungs locked. Panic hit so fast it felt old.

Dead again.

Just like the last time and the time before that.

"Breathe," Viv said.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Her voice was everywhere and nowhere.

"We're loading a test level now."

I forced air into myself. Remembered lungs. Remembered the program.

I am not dead. I am remembering, and this remembering will pass.

"Give me a body model," I said.

"Humanoid?"

I thought about the bus. I thought about rotors. I thought about the way a weapon platform makes violence feel like posture.

"Grab rabbit01.stl from my harness."

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Nate laughed so loud Viv's mic clipped.

"A rabbit? What is this, Easter Sunday?"

"I had to be a monster out there," I said. My tone did not change. "In the Dive and out. I want a fresh start. Something small. Kind. Something nobody would send over a battlefield."

Viv did not say I was already those things.

She knew better.

Then she loaded the rabbit.

There is a moment in every successful interface where the body stops being a picture and becomes a fact.

Ears first.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Ridiculous, I know. The ears were the first thing that landed. Not visually. Positionally. A long, delicate awareness above me. Then weight in the hind legs. Center of gravity low and ready. Hands wrong, paws right, spine folded around a different idea of danger.

I moved.

Not piloted. Not controlled.

Moved.

The test level was a bar from an old JRPG Nate had grown up playing, a second-floor place in Japan with four repeating textures, six stools, and a wall scroll rendered by someone who had never seen paper. It looked horrible.

It was ours.

"Jack?" Viv said.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I hopped onto the bar and cried so hard the headset lost cheek contact.

Nobody wrote that part in the launch history but I did. I cried and cried into my paws, because for once in my life I felt like something that could be loved. Not a weapon. Not a monster.

A fucking bunny rabbit in a third-rate simulation of a bar.

Nobody writes that part into the release notes.

Now you have it.

We spent the entire night building out two more sets. We tried sharing but the early models got really sweaty and honestly, it was time to build the beta models.

We had been working on avatar-swapping when I met Anabelle.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

We obsessed with experimentation. Rabbit was easy. Rabbit was chosen. But then Nate wanted feedback on his flight sim, and that was too close to drone piloting.

I jacked out hard enough to knock a tray of leads off the workbench. The real room hit me all at once: heat, wires, old coffee, takeout containers, Viv's meds, Nate's socks under the table, the sour electric smell of hardware running hotter than its warranty. Viv and Nate were still under, motionless in their chairs. For one stupid second they looked dead.

That did it.

I needed air.

I had not showered in two days. I had not been outside except to collect deliveries. The house had become a lab, and the lab had become a skull. I couldn't remember what was real and what lived inside the Zoo anymore.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I walked.

Anabelle was sitting on the low wall by the playground fence, kicking her heels against the brick like she was waiting for someone and had decided not to care whether they came. She was too casual about being unsupervised. Too good at reading whether an adult was safe. That landed in my body before my brain had a file for it.

"Hey kiddo." I waved. She looked at me like I was a crazy person - and true, I did spend most of my day as a bunny rabbit - but what came out wasn't disgust. It was curiosity.

"You busy playing with your Viewport?"

"Excuse me?" I said.

"My friend got one too. Says it's crazy addictive."

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

"What about you?"

"Dad doesn't like me playing videogames." She looked away. "But I make my own in my school harness. You have to do a lot of hacking to get it to cooperate."

I should have walked away.

That sentence contains most of the history of the world.

But I knew. I knew.

"We're building a better one." I said, and I laid a wink on her. "If you want to see the hardware, bring a parent so everybody knows I'm on the up and up."

She nodded like this was a reasonable adult sentence.

She did not bring a parent.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

She came to the garage later that day, or maybe the next. Memory compresses around the parts you keep relitigating. The door was open because the diodes on my left hemisphere were on the fritz. I had gone inside for a soldering iron. She slipped in because she heard the test rig moving.

The perimeter alarm chirped.

Not a siren. A small ugly sound I had built myself.

My body reacted like it was Hsinchu.

K-bar in my hand before I knew I had picked it up. Body between the intruder and the room. Grip correct. Shoulders correct. Strong hands. Military.

Anabelle screamed.

The garage became a garage again.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I dropped the knife.

Not threw. Dropped. Like it had burned me.

"I'm sorry," I said. "Old habits."

She stared at the knife on the floor.

"That is a knife."

"It is. I am putting both hands where you can see them."

"You already put it down."

"I'm doing both."

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I got lower. Not too close. Hands visible. There is a way to apologize to a scared kid that is really asking the kid to make you feel better. I tried not to do that. I had already done enough.

"Where are your parents?"

"They let me roam."

"That is not what I asked."

She kicked at the concrete. Watched my face. Watched the door. Watched the knife. Watched all three again. Like it was normal.

I knew her look like a gunny knows his rifle.

Nate was the one who said no when I brought her inside.

He was right.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

"Jack, no," he said. "We do not beta-test on the neighborhood children."

"She's not a beta tester."

"She is a child in our garage with no parent and a prototype built from classified-adjacent inference."

"Adjacent is doing a lot of work there."

"So is 'child,'" Anabelle said, protesting. "I'm sixteen."

Vivian sat at the kitchen table with one hand wrapped around a mug she had forgotten to drink from. Her cane leaned against her chair. She listened to us the way she listened to systems: not for who won, but for where the load wanted to go.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

"If she found the door," Viv said, "the least we can do is make sure the room on the other side is safe."

Nate looked at her.

Not a sitcom look. Not henpecked. Partnership language. He knew when Vivian had already decided something and was giving him a chance to arrive with dignity.

"Fine," he said. Then, to Anabelle, "You touch nothing unless one of us says it is okay."

"What if it's on fire?"

"Then you may touch the door."

She smiled. That was handshake enough between us.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I strapped her into my rig and showed her the test room.

No angels sang. No light poured down from the ceiling. It was a rigged-up bar with a terrible texture pack and collision bugs in the stools. But Anabelle stood there with the headset in her hands and asked the question again, quieter this time.

"Can I be taller?"

The first stranger I let into the Zoo was a kid who needed a door. And somehow, despite everything, I built just the right one.

You need to understand the bus.

Not forgive it. Not contextualize it into mush. Understand the shape of the math.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Hsinchu Science Park was the hinge of civilization. Everybody knew it. Politicians pretended not to. Generals found cleaner nouns. Commentators said supply chain because blood chain did not test well.

Whoever held the fabs held tomorrow by the throat.

In exponential times, six months is not six months. Six months is the difference between intercepting a missile after launch and intercepting the industrial process that would have built the missile in the first place. Six months is nanobot clouds thick enough to turn Tomahawk IIIs into bad weather. Six months is one side of the curve eating the other side's future.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

So we held a two-kilometer perimeter around a building that was not actually the asset, because systems under stress love protecting symbols. The people were the asset. The engineers. The operators. The ones who knew the fabs like Stradivarius knew violins. Most of them walked out through every evacuation we failed to notice because we were busy watching the roads.

The bus was on Guangfu Road.

It had children on it.

It crossed the line.

I fired.

I laughed.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

That is the part people want me to soften. I will not. I laughed because the rules had finally said the quiet part in a language even my nervous system could understand. I laughed because the monstrous trolley problem had arrived with a sound system zip-tied to the roof and a woman in a habit at the wheel. I laughed because the procedure worked. The thing no human being should ever have been asked to do had been made clean, legible, authorized, and efficient.

The strike bought time.

Time bought output.

Output bought the curve.

The curve bought the war, or delayed losing it, which is what winning had become by then.

The math worked.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

I came home from a war where crossing the line meant I killed you.

Then I built a place whose only promise was that crossing the line would not.

The math is not as different as I would like.

We did not hire a child.

That is the legal sentence.

The true sentence is worse and kinder: a child found the room where the adults were building a door, and she made herself useful before we could decide whether stopping her would be mercy or cruelty.

By that first winter the Zoo had a user who wasn't one of us, and she was good at QA because she did not trust the room.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Adults test the path they expect. Anabelle tested the path she would need if the room lied.

She checked exits first. She tried to sit where the sim said no one would sit. She noticed NPCs ignored small bodies unless the body made a noise first. She asked what happened if a user refused the assigned avatar. She broke onboarding because she would not click I agree until she understood who could see her.

"My sister would hate this menu," she said once.

I was under a desk, elbows deep in a cable mess.

"Why?"

"Too many choices before it lets you leave."

"That is terrifyingly good notes."

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

"It's annoying notes."

"Most good notes are annoying," I said, and she almost smiled before the sim pulled her back under.

The first time we met Anabelle's parents was over a drawing of Fulldive's older, more ancient cousin.

I insisted on permission. I had learned nothing and everything from the knife. Anabelle looked at me like I had asked her to fly with no wings, but she took us.

Viv did the talking because I looked like military-grade trouble and Nate was too smooth for that room. Their father recognized me as someone doing well in the new economy and hated me on sight. Their mother hovered behind him with a laundry basket against her hip and a face worn into permanent apology.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

"Your Anabelle has been indispensable to our project," Viv said.

"Our what?" he said.

"Project," Viv said. "It means she is smarter than both of us in ways we keep finding expensive to replace."

Nate smiled the smile that makes bank managers and nurses feel heard.

"You will always know where she is," he said.

That line comforted them.

It comforted us.

I hate that it comforted us.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

We made it official-ish. A contract and a wage. A spare key. A standing invitation for all-night hackathons. A chair at the table. A user profile with restrictions nobody liked and everyone pretended were enough. Viv asked what avatar she wanted.

Anabelle crossed her arms. "Has to be cute."

"Of course."

"Something with armor."

"What kind?" Viv asked.

"The kind people believe."

Nate wrote that one on the whiteboard and circled it three times, pointing for emphasis. A cat; something soft and helpful, but all claws if pushed too far.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

It stuck.

Ana — she went by Ana, once she opened up, and that mattered more than I told her at the time — caught me after a long session one Thursday. I was in the transition space between the Zoo and the real world, headset in hand, room still deciding which version of itself it wanted to be.

"I made you something," she said.

She was trying to be casual about it. She wasn't quite pulling it off.

She had started from the same sim Nate did — the flight test, the one I had jackknifed out of three months earlier, the one that put flight math in my hindbrain and a K-bar in my hand before my eyes were open. She had kept the physics. She had changed everything else.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

"I just slapped a skin on it," she said. Which was the modesty version of what she had actually done.

It was a porch. Somewhere rural and warm. Old wood, potted herbs, a couple of sorry-looking lawn chairs. Afternoon light. The feeder hung from a hook in the corner, bright red plastic, full.

She had built it for rabbit. The sight lines were low, the collision mesh was right, the feeder hook sat exactly at ear height if you sat up on your haunches.

"You have to just wait," she said. She was in a small window at the edge of the sim, the way Viv sometimes appeared when she was monitoring without intruding. "It takes a minute."

I waited.

The hummingbird came in from the left.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

Fast. That's always the first thing — the speed of them, the mechanical efficiency, the way they fold and correct and hold position like they're solving a problem nobody else can see. My hind legs tensed. Some part of my nervous system started calculating intercept vectors.

Then the hummingbird was me, and I was looking down at a rabbit minding his own business on the ground.

I panicked at first, but the gentle country winds set wind chimes tingling.

I tilted, and my new body just moved. I leaned forward to the feeder and drank the sweet, sweet nectar. Beak in. Hovering. A small impossible thing doing the work of being alive.

"Whenever you're ready," Ana said. She stood inside a small home and watched through an open window. I flew over. She offered a finger and I obliged.

CHAPTER 3 · Permissions · CONTINUED

"It's gorgeous," I said. My wings were a blur I couldn't feel.

"You can fly here for as long as you want," she said. "I'll stay here and watch over you. Vivian said you needed an excuse to fly again, and — no. It's a thank-you. For giving me a chance."

"I know," I said. Then I flew free over the procedural prairie, the wind beneath my wings and the sun in my eyes.

We didn't mean to hire family, but Ana became it in that moment.

Goodgirl.tv

Gemini, a lifelong puppygirl influencer bred by audience vote, becomes CancerCancer in the Zoo: an anonymous sim artist whose rooms ask what people think instead of what they look like.

Impossible Room

That's the part nobody believes when I try to explain the work. You don't build the room and then walk in. You walk in and the room decides, around you, what it's willing to be.

Out there I'm a good girl. In the Zoo, cordoned off in my own private room, I am an architect.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

There's no panel open, no graph, no little glowing number telling me how many people have wandered through the half-finished thing and bounced off the missing floor and left. I don't build like that. I have never once built that into a room of mine and I'm not going to start. I don't want to know who's watching. The whole point of the room is that the room doesn't know either. You come in, you wander, and somewhere around the third wrong ending, you stop performing for the architecture because the architecture has said: "You are safe, and failure is normal." Identity is discovered by wandering. Not assigned by committee. That's the only thing I've ever managed to mean.

The problem is the secret door. I've hidden one — a seam in the third stairwell that should open if you lean the wrong way against a wall that doesn't read as a wall — and I can't tell anymore whether it's findable or whether I've buried it so deep that only I will ever fall through it.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

That's the failure state of building alone. You hide a thing so well you become the only person who can find it, and then it isn't hidden, it's just lost, with you standing next to it. I need someone who finds doors the way other people find excuses. Someone who goes looking in the pipes.

Viv chirps in my harness.

"You know you could phone a friend," she says.

"Wanna come tap around for me?" I answer. "Might take a while to find a secret door."

"You know who."

She's right, and I'm annoyed by it, but I can't go down without a fight.

"He's here, you know. Next room over. Did you walk through the sim he made for Jamie?"

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

The humor drains from my face.

"He's a sweetheart and you know it." Her voice nudges — a skill I didn't know voices had until she did it.

I had walked through the sim he made for Jamie. He'd left it open — didn't know to lock anything, you could tell — and it was the size of a closet and it had no business being that good.

"I can help him," I tell her. "And helping him is a path back to me, if anybody walks it backward hard enough."

She doesn't tell me to be brave. I'd have hated that. She doesn't tell me it's safe, because it isn't, and she doesn't lie. She just says, in that low deliberate cadence she has, every word chosen and load-bearing: "Kindness still counts when it has a risk surface."

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

And then, because she is the least sentimental person I have ever loved: "I gave you a door without making you prove who you were. It cost me something. Not everything. Enough." She lets that sit. "You're allowed to decide it's worth it. You're not allowed to pretend it's free."

So I do it the only way I know how, which is the way I do everything — quietly, sideways, with manners. Not a broadcast. Not CancerCancer's name in lights. A masked path: his room surfacing in the right wander-maps, a private nudge to a contest judge who'll think she found him herself, a thread in an impossible-room channel lighting up in a way Geoff will never be able to trace back to the hand that lit it. Enough pressure to let the people who need him find him. Not enough to turn him into content. A key, handed to specific people, with the understanding that a key is a thing you offer and not a thing you announce.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

It feels tender. It also feels, faintly, like a thing that could be used for something other than tenderness, and I don't have the wisdom yet to be scared of that, so I'm not. I just know the kid needs a door and I happen to have a key.

So I make a plan.

Give him a key without revealing your celebrity secret.

Easy as pie, I'm sure, but then there's one of mom's many chimes ringing in my ears, and I know my day is about to get ruined.

Chime Taxonomy

It lands in the spine first, a specific two-note thing, and my ears are already pinned flat before I've consciously registered which life is calling. That's the tell. Twenty-eight years of training and I still flatten my ears at a sound. Pavlov was an audience.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

I know the whole fx library by ear. The medication reminder is a soft descending triad, because someone in branding decided my engineered metabolism should be a gentle marketing opportunity. The brand-deal calendar push is brighter, two ascending, good news incoming. The livestream warning is a single clean tone with no warmth in it at all, the only honest sound in the set. And then there's mom, which is its own chime, slightly cheerier than the others, because brand-mom is cheery. Brand-mom has always been cheery. I could not tell you the sound my mother makes when she is not being cheery.

I'm not sure I've heard it. I'm not sure it has a chime.

It's the management tone. I let it sit there in my chest for a second, ears down, in the unfinished stairwell, and I think we should take this before it escalates, and then I hear myself — we — and I put it down like a hot pan. There is no we. There's me. There's the room. There's a two-note sound that wants my stepsister back.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

It's a cameo. Last-minute, a local gallery that can't afford the rate and isn't going to be charged it. They don't make money, sweetheart, Mom says, like that's the pitch — like generosity is the angle, and not the fact that an unpaid favor for a sympathetic little gallery is exactly the kind of warm, uncynical content the numbers have been starving for. Neither do you, I say, not quite out loud, into the fur at my own shoulder where the mic isn't.

I take it.

The collective couldn't swing an in-person, so I trudge the pedways to the studio, lock into the rig, and let the goodgirl have the controls.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

The cameo keeps the numbers warm. The numbers keep my parents off the cliff they've been sliding down in slow motion since before I was a poll question — two career influencers who can read an engagement curve in the dark and watched their own start to bend the wrong way right around the time I learned to talk. That's the barrel I'm over. Perform, or let the people who built me go broke. They never have to say it out loud. They built a chime that says it for them.

I wrote a sim about this once. Called it Zugzwang. You play chess against an engine that doesn't just beat you, it toys with you first — runs the position long past won, because winning was never the point. It wants you to feel it being better than you. It never says a word. It doesn't have to. Every move is the sentence. Nobody who bought it ever asked why a dog made a game about a trap where it's still your turn and there's nothing good left to do.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

That sim, dropped on the open net for people who had to go looking for it, cleared less than this thirty-minute favor I'm doing for free. I hate her sometimes. Goodgirl makes the rent.

So I sit in the back room with no windows and watch her work. The stylist who doesn't knock. Makeup, boom, talent — and talent is me, the body, the one job in the room every other job depends on. She smiles for the holo rig, tongue lolling, every hair captured at every angle, and the gallery's little crowd lights the feed with popups every time she does something doglike on cue: the head tilt, the ears, the whole-body wag they paid nothing for and got anyway.

They throw a ball. She brings it back. The chat loves it.

I think about Geoff. Maybe I could make him something. A room. A game. A door.

No. Too dangerous.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

They throw the ball again and goodgirl chases it again. None of them ask what I feel. They never have. No one cares what the entertainment has to think.

Goodgirl.tv

That is goodgirl.tv, if you strip the graphics off. Seven and a half million viewers are jacked into my consciousness, each one with their own reasons. Some are curious. Others are lurid. I've served them all. As a real-life puppygirl, I'm bred to not judge.

The viewers receive an exact copy of my synapses. Every ear-flick, tail-wag, and itch on my body becomes purchasable property, and as long as I keep up my end of the bargain I don't end up poor.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

I make a point to pant, to let the tags on the collar ring, to slurp the water bowl loud enough for the mic — that plays well on the ASMR market, for one, and for two it lets the viewers open a donation bounty, my dad's idea, and the number climbs high enough that I'll sit. Roll over. Show the camera my belly and hold it there, soft and stupid and obedient, while the chat goes good girl, good girl, good girl and the counter spins.

People buy from me because I'm the best. My braindances are like the craziest dream you've ever had. When you strap in you don't see me roll over, you are me rolling over: you get the good-girl flood in your own chest, the warmth, the whole felt thing, played back at whatever fidelity you paid for. That's the product. Not my face. Not the footage. The braindance can't counterfeit what isn't there. The rig records what the body actually felt. So the body actually has to feel it.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

Which is the part I solved early. I don't have to be home for it. I learned young how to step back and let the goodgirl have the controls — she's better at this than I am, she was bred for it, she means every second — and I go somewhere with no windows and wait. The body fronts. The body feels it, all the way down, for real. The rig drinks the real thing straight from the source, and somewhere I'm not, a hundred thousand strangers wear my genuine joy like a coat they rented. I come back when the counter stops. They got to feel more of me than I was in the room for.

And here's the part I can't get a therapist to sit still for: it works on me too. Not just on her. I can step back but I can never fully unplug the wiring — some of the good-girl flood always reaches the back room where I'm hiding, warm and loose and grateful, the honest chemical kind that has no off switch and no opinion about whether I'd choose it, and for one second, every time, every single time, I am exactly as happy as they built me to be. That is the design. A creature that fought would have been a worse product; they wanted one that floods on cue, so they bred one, and called the

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

flood consent, and sold it by the minute. I roll over because the number got high enough. I love it because they made sure I would. Those are not the same surrender and they live in the same body, and I have never once managed to get either of them out.

Goodgirl almost feels like a stepsister inside my head. Mom and Dad made her a dog. My genes are the result of a vote-with-your-wallet donation marathon that brought my parents a fortune and bought me a pedigree. Best in show. The audience picked the breed and my parents installed it and the breeders signed off and nobody in that chain was a legal person who could be asked, least of all me.

And they called me Cancer because of a meme, so that's good too.

I remember how good-girl would light up for the cameras, all that eager, all that want-to-please she couldn't switch off — and then there was the reality stream, the spinoff movies, the ad campaigns. She did well for herself.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

But still. A stepsister. Yeah. I just wish that when I looked in the mirror, her face wasn't the one looking back at me.

So I built somewhere with no mirrors. No cameras. No her.

The Fundraiser

I met Vivian because of a cane.

This was years ago, before CancerCancer was anything but a small spiteful brand I'd started the way you'd start a fire in a wastebasket — a developer tooling con, all SDK booths and embodiment middleware and full-dive demos, the kind where I was the shiny keynote object and somebody had written the future of embodied authenticity on a placard with my face on it. My handlers had clocked the blind woman at the reception as safe. Good optics, no eye contact to manage, won't post anything we can't control. That was their read. It was the most expensive misread of their careers and they billed it

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

as a win.

She was feeling along the wall for the bathroom signage and I knew the move from the inside, because the eyes they gave me are beautiful and don't work — a hereditary thing, the kind purebreds carry, the cost folded into the look — and I spent a chunk of my childhood at low-vision camps learning the same hand-along-the-wall I was watching her do.

"Ladies is on the left," I said. "Would you like help?"

"Sure." She took my arm, found the fur, and didn't miss a beat.

"Fursuit, in May?" she said. "Dedication."

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

It wasn't a fursuit and she knew it wasn't — you can feel the difference, real fur warm at the root over a real arm, and she'd had her hands on enough of the world to read it by touch. She just wasn't impressed. She had her palm on the single most expensive piece of audience-generated content in three markets and she filed it under weather. And that gave me a rush I didn't have a name for, because every other hand that ever found that fur gripped it like a winning ticket, and hers just used it to get to the bathroom.

I walked her in. She did her business. And on the way out she put it together — not the dog, the voice, the cadence, the work — and she said, delighted, "Oh! You're CancerCancer. Dog fur. Should have put it together!"

She knew the sims. She knew my sims. Could name her favorite version of my first three hand-made sims that I'd dropped around the neighborhood under the brand. She did not know the face that built them. She'd come at me from the only direction nobody comes at me from.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

"This is new."

"What, meeting a fan?"

"Just.." I went to make a gesture and got flustered. She heard it of course.

Vivian laughed. "Oh! You expected me to be shocked! Lady, I'm blind. I can't see you. Why would I care if you're a dog?"

It was rude. It was rude enough to be the kindest thing anyone had ever said to me. Every adult in my life had hit my ears first, every single one, since before I could hold my head up, and she physically could not, and more than that she chose not to, and into the crack that opened she put the question. Not what does it feel like to be you. Not what do you want people to understand about your body. What do you think.

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I didn't have an answer. That was the terrifying part. I'd been built to have answers — I'd given this one seven hundred times, in greenrooms and comment threads and on panels while my handlers watched the clock for the off-ramp. The brand answer lives in the chest, pre-loaded, it finds its own way out. But she wasn't asking the brand. She was asking me. And the me she was asking had never been asked before, and there was nothing there. Just a clean absence. I opened my mouth in that hallway and heard myself not talking. Listened to it. I don't know how long.

"I think I make things," I said, finally. "I think that's all I know about it."

She nodded, like it was already somewhere to go.

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They sat us next to each other on a panel that afternoon — me for the spectacle, her for Fulldive, head of operations, the one who actually kept the company breathing. Someone in the third row was fidgeting with a tennis ball, tossing it an inch and catching it, tossing and catching, and I had to physically anchor my eyes to the moderator's face to keep them from tracking the arc. I was winning that fight. And then another panelist — the embodiment researcher from whatever university, kind face, zero clue — turned to me after I answered something and said, warmly, genuinely, with total

innocence: "That's a good girl."

My face did what my face does.

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The smile that comes up is not the one I choose. It's wider than that, and it shows more teeth, and there's a specific quality to the breathing that goes with it. I know because I've watched the footage. I have watched the footage many times, in the way you watch something you cannot believe happened and cannot stop proving happened. The room made a sound — not cruel, worse than cruel, the warm delighted sound of an audience getting what they came for — and I sat there with my face doing the thing my face does, while the counter behind my eyes went there it is, there it is, there it is.

Vivian didn't react. She was in the chair next to me and she could not see my face and she did not hear a performing dog, she heard a room having a moment, and she did not give it the attention it was bidding for. She caught a question about latency and turned it into a question about who gets designed out of a default, which in her hands was the same question, and the room's attention went with her. I got my face back. I don't know if she knew what she'd done.

I lost the thread of the panel anyway, because I couldn't get past the plain fact of her in the next chair: a body, warm, gesturing, ankles crossing and uncrossing, a whole woman running on her own two legs. That's the part I have to work to remember now — that there was a season I knew Vivian with hands, before the car. I keep reaching for it and it keeps sliding.

Bridge Game

Old-school night was Nate's idea, and like most of his ideas it was supposed to be a one-time thing and then it just stayed.

Bridge. He built the decks himself — braille-readable, every card tactile, fully usable for Viv, which is the kind of thing he does, the small precise generous thing nobody asked for. A human, a snake, a blind fox, and a rabbit around a table. Dogs Playing Poker, if the dogs had better taste and a worse secret.

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I thought, briefly, about how well a charity card game would sell but —

No. I'm the human tonight. Work can wait. That's the thing the Zoo lets me do that the world never will — wear the body the poll vetoed, the one I'd have had if a few thousand strangers hadn't picked the breed standard before I had a spine to object with. So I sit down at old-school night in a borrowed human face and human hands and no ears at all, and I think I've left the dog in the other life. I haven't. You'll see. I never do.

It's me and Nate against Vivian and Jack. Bridge is a signal game — the whole negotiation happens silently, in the bidding, partner reading partner across a table neither of them is allowed to talk across. My job is to get inside Nate's head and stay there. I'm good at getting inside people. It's the one place my training pays rent: being read in service of a partnership instead of being read as a product is a kind of room I didn't know I'd been starving for, and I sink into it.

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Our hands run good. They run a little too good. I've noticed it before and I notice it again tonight — the cards fall toward us with a smoothness that real shuffling doesn't have, a seam in the randomness I can feel the way I can feel a wall that isn't reading as a wall. He built the decks. He built the decks and I am almost certain he left himself a little something in the build, a way to top-deck a good hand into our partnership when he wants one, and I have never once called it.

I tell myself it's because I can't prove it. That's not why. I like the partner. I don't want to look harder at the partner. And — this is the ugly one, the one I file three folders deep — I enjoy the good hands. He made me complicit before I understood there were terms. By the time I understood the terms I was already winning.

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He asks me something across the table — not a bid, a real question, in the dead space while Viv sorts her tactile cards by feel. Asks what I'm working on, and the question assumes I have an opinion worth having, lands warm, lands exactly on the soft part of me that has spent its whole life waiting to be asked. And there's a half-second where the warmth has a texture to it. Smooth. A degree too precisely aimed.

My ears go back. I'm not wearing ears. And somewhere I'm not wearing a tail, something tries to tuck. That's the dog for you — the one part of me that never logs out, pinning a pair of ears I left in another body, on a borrowed human skull, because the animal underneath the brand has read the room faster than I have. It's the only honest instrument I own. They bred it onto me to sell merchandise and it turns out it also works. And I do what I have done with that instrument my whole life, every time it has tried to warn me about a person being warm at me on purpose: I notice it, I look at the

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warmth, and I weigh how good it feels to be aimed at correctly for once. That's the thing nobody tells you about being built to please: it doesn't check credentials. It floods for whoever learns the trick of you. The same bred-in eagerness that goes warm for good girl is going warm now, for a man who got the inputs right. So I file the pinned ears under well-behaved, and I make my bid.

Viv wins the hand anyway, reading Jack across the silence the way only two people who've been signal to each other for decades can. She doesn't gloat. She tilts her head at the table like she's listening to something the rest of us can't hear, which she usually is. Her silence at this table costs nothing — that's the whole gift of her, the only silence in my life that was ever free. Everyone else's silence about me has had a price tag. Hers is just a refusal to look, offered with both hands.

Then she looks in my direction, and I know I'm cooked.

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"When are you gonna show that poor mouse your work, Gemini?"

"Your work?"

Nate leans in closer, his body slithering up and forward, as if ready to receive a secret.

"Oh, I make sims. Nothing much."

I take the cards and shuffle them. It's not my deal but I need something to do, someone to yell at me, anything to save me from what this mad fox woman is about to do.

"She's quite good," Viv goes on. "And I keep saying she should share it more."

"Whose deal is it?" I hold up the deck.

No one offers an out.

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That's the problem with genuine friends — they don't let you hide from your own shine.

"Okay."

"Okay?"

"Starting with you three," I say, standing. "Because I gotta work up to this."

We put down the cards. I take them through.

You can't walk three people into a room you built without learning exactly who they are by the way they walk it. Jack goes in like a contractor — straight to the load-bearing trick, the stairwell that picks its own direction, running a hand down the logic of it the way you'd check a weld. How did you — no, how did you. The builder recognizing the build. That I can survive. Praise for the engineering goes in a pocket I can close.

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Nate goes in slower. He doesn't touch anything. He stands in the middle and turns one slow circle and takes the whole thing in like a man doing inventory, getting to the number before he gets to the kindness, and when the kindness comes it's perfect — this is real work, Gemini. This is the real thing. It lands exactly where I keep the soft part. The not-ears go back again. And again I file it under a friend being generous, because the alternative is looking, and looking is the thing that was done to me, not the thing I do. So I let the good hand sit in my hand and I don't turn it over.

And Vivian can't see a single wall of it. She stands just inside the door with her head tilted, listening to the room the way she listens to everything — and catches the layer I buried in the air for nobody, the one no one with working eyes has ever once stopped to hear. She's quiet a long time.

"Oh," she says. "Oh, it's beautiful."

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Not you're beautiful. Not you're so talented, sweetheart, the way the chyron used to say it under a face that wasn't mine. It. The thing I made. She gives the whole compliment to the room and lets me stand next to it instead of inside it, which is the only spot I have ever been able to breathe, and for one second nobody at that table is wondering what I feel like.

They're standing in what I feel.

The Fox Is There Again

She'd just done it again, at the table — turned every eye in the room onto the work and off the dog, the only person alive who thinks to. The fox, there again. The fox was always there again.

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By then again was the honest word for it. The con hadn't been the only time. She'd turned up at a panel I was booked on, then a workshop, then some library thing I'd half forgotten I'd agreed to — never with a handler, never with an angle, never wanting a single thing off the dog. Just there, the way weather is there. I'd started, without deciding to, looking for her in rooms before I knew whether she'd come. That should have frightened me more than it did.

My first show. Before the Zoo, before the car, before she was a voice in a harness and a friend. Back when CancerCancer was a dozen handmade sims I'd dropped around the neighborhood like a tagger, and somebody with a lease finally let me line them up in a room and call it an opening.

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You did sims in BoxCos then. A booth, a visor, a strap across the back of the skull, thirty seconds of somewhere I'd been. Participants stood there twitching in the dark — batting at dandelions in a sunset that wasn't in the room, flinching at a cold stream on a warm day, going soft in the face at things only they could see.

A gallery is built for eyes. Everybody who came moved through it looking, and afterward they told each other about the light — the low sun, the way the seed-heads caught it. Nobody mentioned the sound. Nobody ever mentions the sound. Audio's the thing creators bolt on last, an afterthought with a volume slider, and the whole room spent the whole night not hearing the part I'd worked hardest on.

And then she came — the woman from the con, the one who'd asked me what I thought and then sat beside me with a body I keep losing. The staff didn't know her from anyone; they read a blind woman at an art opening as a wrong turn and moved to walk her out.

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She didn't want out. She wanted a booth.

She pulled the visor down over eyes that didn't work and stood in my sunset for the full thirty, and when she came out she didn't say one word about the light. She talked about the sound. That the wind in the field had three layers and a near one that shifted when you turned your head. That the stream wasn't a loop — I'd recorded forty minutes and cut it so it never came back around, and she'd stood there long enough to catch that, and she was delighted, lit up like I'd hidden a present in the one corner of the room nobody else walks into. You built the whole thing for someone who'd keep

their eyes shut, she said. I hadn't. Not on purpose. But she was the proof that I had — that I'd been making, the whole time, for the one person who comes at a thing through everything except the look of it.

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And then she pitched me — except a pitch is a thing you brace for, and I didn't brace, because she'd spent weeks earning the right to say it and I'd let her. Blunt, because she's always blunt: they were building something. New sim work, no cameras, no names, nobody asks what you are unless you invite the question. I'd fit. And then quieter, the thing that actually broke the room — she was sorry I didn't have one single person who cared about me past the dog, and she wanted to give me a place.

She mailed me a prototype. I gave her my home address, which my security team would have had a stroke about, and the first time I went into the Zoo I understood I'd been holding my breath for twenty years.

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She did all of it on her own two feet — crossed a gallery to corner the stray she'd decided to keep, lifted the visor with her own two hands, carried a package to a post office. Not one of those is a thing she can do now. The woman who ran me down on foot lives in signal these days, same as I do, except she didn't choose it and I did. So I don't reach for that version of her the way I reach for the rest of what I've lost. I set it down, careful, every time — in the one room in me that was never wired to record.

Geoff Finds the Room

He comes.

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He knows immediately. That's the part that takes the air out of me. He doesn't wander, doesn't poke, doesn't ask what it is. One look at the stairwell choosing its own direction, the seam I buried, the floor that isn't there yet, and he says it hushed, the way you'd say it in a cathedral you hadn't expected to find unlocked: "This is a CancerCancer. This is a real one." Not a fan's guess. A craftsman's certainty. He knows the hand.

And he doesn't know it's mine.

The maker is standing three feet from him, and it's me, and he knows me — we've been circling each other in the Zoo the better part of a year, and in all that time I have never once let on that I make anything at all. That was the deal I cut with myself. He gets Gemini: the friend, the one who turns up and says little and never talks about her day. He does not get the work, because the work is the one piece of me nobody gets. So he's too absorbed in the room to look at the woman standing next to it, and it does not cross his mind that the woman standing next to it is the hand he's gone

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reverent over — and that's the second impossible thing, because nobody keeps taking the work seriously once they learn there's a dog attached to drain the gravity out of it. He doesn't know there's a dog attached. He just stands there giving it the weight it's owed, and it is the most courteous thing anyone has ever done for me without the faintest idea he was doing it.

"Where'd you get your hands on this?"

"Whose did you think it was?" I ask, careful, neutral, the brand-flat voice I can do in my sleep.

"I'd know that hand anywhere," he says, not really to me, already walking the seam.

He finds the buried door.

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I watch him lean into the third stairwell wall — the one that doesn't read as a wall — and feel the seam with the flat of his hand, unhurried, the way you'd check a painting for the brushwork underneath. He doesn't go through. He just stands there with his palm on the place where the room is hiding something from itself.

"You buried it," he says. Not a criticism. A reading.

"I couldn't tell if it was findable anymore."

He thinks about it for a second. "When you're working small," he says, "you have to signpost big. Smallest guy's gotta make the most noise, yaknow? The door's gotta be the loudest thing in the room, or it stops being a door." He pauses. "Unless you wanted it lost."

I don't answer, because I don't know the answer, and that's its own answer. He nods like he heard me anyway and goes back to the seam.

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He says it so easily. The thing I couldn't figure out on my own, the thing I'd been circling for a month — signpost big — and he just puts it down on the floor between us like it's obvious, like he's been handing people this answer his whole life, and I realize: that's the problem. He has. He just doesn't know it's the answer. He doesn't know he has it to give.

And I see the problem in him in the same instant, because it's my problem wearing his face. He has the eye. He has the ethic. He has the hands. What he doesn't have is the audacity — the arrogant, unforgivable claim every artist has to make, I deserve to be heard, the one that feels like arrogance right up until you make it. He can't make it. He probably can't even name why not. It just sits in him as shame wearing humility's coat.

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The masked path I already ran. Untraceable, professional, a hand reaching from a direction he won't think to trace. That was safe — or safe enough. What's happening right now is not. He's inside my room. In a minute he's going to look up. When he does, he's going to finish the math that's already sitting in his chest — I know this hand, and the maker is in this room — and then he'll know CancerCancer is in the Zoo. Whatever stands between that fact and my fans is just him.

My fans are rabid, the real kind, the kind that has my coordinate memorized and boards the same trains and isn't doing anything wrong by their own lights because they love me and they paid for the right. If CancerCancer is seen doing anything here — recommending work, leaving any traceable shape in the Zoo's ecosystem — they will come. They'll bring their whole mode of attention with them. And their attention is the thing the Zoo was built to be without. The Zoo is the one place I have ever been that didn't know how to be an audience for me. My fans would fix that in an afternoon. They'd mean

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to. That's the worst part.

The harness buzzes against my sternum while Geoff is still inside my room. I know the number from the shape of the buzz — I've learned to read the escalation pattern the way you learn a language spoken at you every hour.

I deny it.

I stay.

Rate Card

The number is still climbing. I can feel it in the harness without leaving — the bid running its familiar escalation through the ranges I know by heart.

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I haven't left the room to read it. I've learned not to — you can hold a bid in the harness and a person in the room at the same time, as long as the person only ever feels the half you leave with him. Geoff gets that half. He's still walking my seam, unhurried, no idea a window just opened in the corner of me with a number ticking up inside it.

Someone wants the full roll-over. Belly to camera, the throat, the soft obedient hold. Someone has counter-bid for the trick set: sit, shake, speak, the whole obedience run rendered adorable for a paying room. The two of them escalating in the ticker, the number working toward the one with real commas in it. I know how this ends. There has never been a number high enough that I didn't eventually meet it, and the entire architecture of my life is the standing proof that everything I am has a price. I'll do it later. Not tonight.

Not no. I don't own no. Just not yet, which is the only square the position leaves me — deferral dressed up as a choice, the date the one line on the card I get to fill in myself.

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And I mean a price, an exact one. I am the rate card; I could recite myself from memory. A head-tilt to bring a face into focus clears a known number in reaction. A good girl caught live clears more. A good girl I visibly try not to enjoy clears more than that, because the trying is the content and the content is the product. I keep the whole menu in my head the way other people keep a childhood phone number — it doesn't leave, it was loaded before I had a vote. You don't get to forget what you cost.

And the obscene part — the thing the bounty is actually buying — is that when I finally do it, my body will mean it. The tail goes on its own. The warmth comes whether I clear it or not. They aren't paying me to fake the joy. They are paying for the joy itself, which is real, and which is mine, and which they installed in me before I had a say, so that the most degrading thing they can make me do is also, chemically, the happiest I am all week.

A thing that has a price for everyone has no value to itself.

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That's the sentence the management therapists never get out of me. My life has no value. Not as a sad feeling — as an accounting. I was raised by marketers, I am a marketer, I can read a balance sheet, and on mine every outward inch is priced to the decimal and the inside of me was never listed, because it never went to auction, never moved a number, never generated a single bid. In the only language I was ever taught — the language of what things are worth — a thing nobody will pay for is a thing worth nothing. They valued the outside of me so precisely, so completely, that the sum of all

that value is a person on the inside priced at zero.

Then I go back to the room with no counter, where a mouse who can't stop painting is standing in the middle of something I made — not something I'm worth — and the difference between those two things is most of the reason I'm still alive.

"I want to show you something," I say.

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"Okay."

"Not a room. Something older. I've never shown it to anyone."

His eyes fill with stars. Good boy.

The Robin

And then I do the thing I didn't plan to do, which is show him the robin.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

The old sims aren't a portfolio. I have to explain this to exactly nobody, because I never show them, but they're not work, they're diary. They're how I made anything stick. The world recorded my entire childhood — every shoot, every shed, every voted-for feature arriving on schedule for an audience that watched me become the thing they'd bought — and somewhere in all that footage my actual interior got lost. Too much signal. I couldn't hear what I felt in a moment because the moment was always being captured for someone else, and the capture drowned the feeling. So I learned to build. A sim

catches what the feed couldn't. A sim makes the inside real enough to keep.

The robin is the oldest one.

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I was maybe ten. Equipment broke that afternoon, or my parents were out, I genuinely don't remember which, only that for once nobody was filming me, and a robin started throwing itself at the window. Over and over. Going at its own reflection. It saw a rival in the glass and the threat response was correct — that's the part I couldn't stop watching — the response was right, it just didn't know it was fighting itself, and even if you could've told it, I don't think it could've stopped. I watched it for twenty minutes. Nothing else happened. That's the whole event. A bird and a window and no camera and me.

And it kept slipping out of me afterward — no timestamp, no file, no little number to hang it on — so I built it. Out of an entire crowdsourced childhood, the one thing I chose to make permanent is a bird doing something useless and compelled and true that nobody but me ever saw.

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I don't explain any of that to Geoff. I just open the door and let him walk in, and there's the bird, going again and again at the glass, and he stands there, this mouse who can't stop painting things nobody asked to see, and he gets it from the inside before I've said a word.

"It can't not," he says, finally. Quiet. "The window's right there and it can't not."

"No," I say. "It can't."

And I watch him understand that this was never the audacity problem. It was the audacity answer. It was never arrogance, the thing in him, the thing in the bird, the thing in me. It's just a creature running its correct response to the thing in front of it. You don't get to choose whether you meet the window. You only get to choose whether you build what you saw there.

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He turns around to say something and the math finishes in his face — the work, the old friends, the voice — and he gets there, all the way there, and he says, half-wonder, half-apology, "Gemini. Cancer Pup —"

"Please don't use that name." It comes out softer than I expect. Not the brand reflex. Something older. "My friends call me CeeCee."

He says it back like he's been handed something breakable. "CeeCee." Then, fast, dead serious: "Permission to completely lose it for, like, thirty seconds, tops?"

"Granted," I say.

And while he's losing it — quiet about it, a mouse vibrating in the middle of a bird that won't stop hitting a window — something comes up false on a ledger I've been keeping since before I could read it, and I stand there watching it fail, and I do not explain it, not even to myself, not yet.

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I went in to encourage the kid.

The bird keeps going at the glass.

Offered Key

He still doesn't know everything, I keep telling myself.

He knows CeeCee. He doesn't know goodgirl.tv, the chimes, the poll, the whole machine idling on the other side of the only wall it's never breached. CancerCancer stays outside where she belongs. What he knows is CeeCee, and what CeeCee knows is him, and neither of those things leaves this room. That isn't failure. For the first time in my life it's a thing I chose, with both hands, knowing the cost and paying it anyway — which is the only kind of identity that was ever actually mine.

The door's still open. The key works.

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Viv gave me a key once and never asked to see what I kept behind it. I used to file that under trust. Tonight it reads more like instruction.

And I notice, logging the room shut behind me — locking it this time — that I want something. Want to come back, want to show him the next one, want a whole future of small uncatalogued wants. And I don't, for once, run the count of who would be watching me want it.

I catch the shape of the next one already forming — a room I could build for him, the way you'd pick out a gift, sized to one person with no audience standing behind him. I've made ten thousand things. I have never once made a thing for a single person who'd be the whole reason it existed. The want is so unfamiliar it reads, at first, as fear — and I hold still and let it be there, the way you let a bird settle that you don't want to spook.

CHAPTER 4 · Goodgirl.tv · CONTINUED

The harness goes off. Then again. Then the mother-chime, cheerier than the rest, because brand-mom is always cheery. The chat wants fetch — I can read the bounty shape from the escalation pattern, the way the number is climbing toward the number I have always, predictably, eventually met. My mother's voice starts to come through, warm, already mid-sentence, already walking me to the next item on a call sheet I never agreed to.

Twenty-eight years and I have never once let her chime go unanswered. The chime is the barrel; the barrel is real; the people on the far end of it built me and I love them, which is the part with no off switch. But the chime is out there, and I am in here, and for the length of one breath those are two different rooms and only one of them has me in it.

I put them all on silent.

There's no counter in this room. I didn't build one.

Soft Reset

Anabelle returns to a simulation of one afternoon four years gone—the last day her family felt whole—and discovers that keeping the save is not the same as keeping the past.

The Ritual

My rig lived in a bucket of ice.

Not the whole rig — just the part that mattered, the cooling loop soldered onto the manifold that ran hottest. Kit called it a war crime against small appliances, the one time I showed him. Said I was gonna burn out my brainstem.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

But it's how I go home.

I filled the bucket from the tap, dumped in whatever the freezer still had — three ice trays, half a bag of peas older than my last relationship — and packed it around the loop until the status light stopped its worried orange blink and went to cold, patient blue.

An hour. Maybe ninety minutes if I didn't move much. After that, I could keep going, but the ice stopped making it safe.

Anyway, anyway, anyway.

Outside, the city was doing the thing it did a little earlier every year, which was try to kill everyone in it by six p.m. My building's cooling ration had run out at two. Sweat pooled behind my knees just sitting still. Somewhere below me a compressor that had been dying since spring made its long, grinding case for early retirement.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I didn't turn on a fan. A fan just moves the hot air around so it can hit you from a new angle.

I settled into the chair — a curb rescue from two summers back, foam gone soft in exactly the shape of me by now — and found the jack by feel, the way you find a light switch in your childhood house at two in the morning without looking. Port, just behind the left ear. In.

I know how this looks. A girl icing her own skull to go sit inside a memory. I know it's a sim. I know the restaurant isn't standing anymore, if it ever stood anywhere outside a render farm's private accounting of one Tuesday, four years gone. I know the woman I'm about to have lunch with is not the mother upstairs in this same building, in a completely different sense of the word upstairs.

A soft reset keeps your save.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

That's the whole trick of it, and the whole cruelty. Nothing wipes. The day is exactly the day, every time. Vivian built it with enough rules to keep it from becoming something else. I'm not rewriting my mother.

I come back because it's the only place that afternoon still happens.

That isn't the whole truth anymore. Lately I watch Kat, too — not at the curb, never there, but at the sushi counter, in the half-seconds between plates. I tell myself it's because she was happy that day.

The status light ticked from blue to a color the sim didn't have a name for, which was its way of saying hold on, this is about to feel like falling, and it won't be. The apartment hummed its low, tired hum. Somewhere in the walls, Stinky Pete was almost certainly logging my dive time to a file nobody would read until the day it was the only proof of what had happened to me.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

The ice bought maybe ninety extra seconds of brain before the trip started costing anything real.

Ninety seconds is nothing. The rig wouldn't throw me out after that. It just stopped pretending the trip was free.

Ninety seconds is also the length of an entire afternoon, if it's the right one.

I went under.

The Day

The restaurant was three blocks from the convention center, in a building that had been six different restaurants in six different languages and kept all their old signage bolted somewhere behind the current one. A conveyor belt ran the length of the counter, little colored plates riding around like a toy train nobody had told to stop.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

Mom had her arm looped through mine before we'd even gotten our badges scanned off — hers still clipped to her blazer from the demo floor, mine borrowed, a size too big, EXHIBITOR GUEST in letters she couldn't see and I didn't bother reading out loud, because she already knew what it said. She always knew what things said. It took me years to understand that not seeing a sign and not knowing what it said were two completely different problems, and that my mother had solved the second one for herself long before I showed up to help with the first.

"Tell me the belt," she said, once we'd sat down, the way you'd ask someone to read a menu, except the menu wouldn't hold still for it.

So I told her the belt.

"Salmon, going away from us. Something orange — tamago, egg, maybe. A plate with three pieces and no cover, so it's been out a while, skip it. Tuna. More tuna. Oh — there's a good one, the one with the sauce that drips."

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"The seared one."

"The seared one. Coming back around. Want it?"

"Grab it when it's close."

I grabbed it when it was close. That became, without either of us deciding it on purpose, the whole afternoon: me narrating a small circular parade, my mother's hand finding the plate at exactly the right second because I'd told her exactly the right second, food arriving in her hands like she'd ordered it out of the air.

Kat had never had sushi.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

She said so like a confession, mouth already full of the one roll on the belt that looked like food she trusted, and then declared war on a pair of chopsticks the waiter had rubber-banded together at the hinge — the kids' trick, training wheels for a person who'd never done this before. She had the band off before he'd even turned around.

"I don't need the baby ones," she said.

She very much needed the baby ones. She spent the next twenty minutes in open negotiation with two loose, uncooperative sticks, refusing, on principle, to ask for the rubber band back.

"You're holding it like a shovel," I told her.

"I'm holding it like it deserves."

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"Here." I got behind her, moved her fingers one at a time — this one stays still, this one moves. Four tries. On the fifth she got a single grain of rice from the plate to her mouth and looked up at me like she'd split the atom.

"I did the thing," she said.

"You did the thing."

A stool opened up on Kat's other side around then — someone finished and left, badge lanyard swinging — and it didn't stay empty long. Conventions like that one didn't leave anything empty long. Some guy slid onto it mid-plate, and though I didn't turn to look at him directly, I caught the peripheral impression of rolled shirtsleeves and an active phone—the universal shape of a man taking a break from being professionally interesting to strangers. He didn't say anything to us. We didn't say anything to him. That was the whole point of a counter like that — you sat close enough to touch and

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

owed each other nothing.

Kat went quiet for a second, the way she did sometimes around people she didn't know, and I remember thinking, distantly, she'll warm up, and reaching for the next plate, because there was always a next plate, and I had a belt to keep narrating.

Mom ordered a drink with a paper umbrella that the waiter had to describe to her twice, and Kat got the kiddie cocktail off the laminated kids' menu she'd insisted she was too old for right up until it arrived — something blue and virgin and sweet, a cherry on a little plastic sword, two straws for no reason anyone explained — and I got nothing, officially, because I was old enough to know better and young enough that Mom slipped me a sip of hers anyway, under the belt, like contraband.

It tasted like a vacation. Not the drink. All of it.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

The plates kept coming. You didn't order, you didn't run out. You reached when you wanted and the world put something in your hand, and there was always more coming around the bend whether you'd asked for it or not. A machine built entirely on the promise that scarcity was somebody else's problem. At least here. At least for an hour. At least for us.

Dad found us an hour and a half in, tie loosened, badge flipped backwards, apologizing before he'd even pulled out the chair. He and his business partner had gotten cornered past the demo booth by three investors and a journalist who wouldn't take the hint, and he said it like you'd apologize for traffic — an inconvenience, nothing more, no idea yet what that partnership would cost this family, or how many more afternoons he'd lose to people who wanted a piece of what he'd built.

He kissed the top of Kat's head. He put his hand on the back of Mom's chair without touching her, which she somehow always knew was there anyway.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"You started without me," he said, looking at the belt.

"We didn't start," Kat said, mouth full again. "We're never going to stop. That's the whole point."

"Fair," he said, and reached out and took whatever was closest, and ate it, and didn't ask what it was.

That was the first time I believed it — watching my little sister do chopsticks with her tongue between her teeth, my mother's hand finding my father's without looking, everyone fed, nobody keeping score. We made it. She's going to be okay. Somebody's going to look out for her.

I didn't know yet what that sentence would cost.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

Afterward we walked along the river, because the day had one more good idea in it and none of us wanted to be the one to say no. The water was the color rivers get in cities that have stopped pretending the water is clean, and none of us cared. Kat found a rock she decided was a good rock and put it in her pocket like she meant to keep it forever. I think she still has it, somewhere, in a box, in a house none of us live in the same way anymore.

Four of us, walking. My mother's hand in my father's. My sister two steps ahead, already living somewhere none of the rest of us could follow her yet — the way she always did, the way none of us thought to worry about until it was much too late.

For one afternoon, we were exactly enough people, doing exactly enough, and nothing in the world was coming to take it from us.

The Curb

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I know the exact paving stone where it happens, if a sim can be said to have exact paving stones, if a memory can be said to have geography instead of just impressions arranged badly.

Third stone past the mailbox with the sticker peeling off the front. That's where the car doesn't stop.

I've walked up to that stone maybe two hundred times.

Not the whole day, every time — I used to run the whole thing start to finish, sushi and river and everything, like I owed the good parts a full viewing before I was allowed to want the bad part. I don't do that anymore. I skip straight to the walk now, four of us on the sidewalk, my mother's hand loose in my father's, and let the good afternoon compress down to nothing so I can get to the part where I try to fix it.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

This time — every time — I let go of my father's other hand a half-block early. I start closing the distance before I even know I'm doing it, the way you start running toward a sound before your brain finishes deciding it was a scream.

Third stone past the mailbox.

The car doesn't slow down. It never slows down. It takes the corner wide, the way corners get taken by men who are late for something small enough that the lateness still felt urgent, back before the whole world agreed that everyone was always going to be late for everything now.

I get my arm out.

Every time, I get my arm out — that's the part the sim lets me have, the reaching, the wanting, the half-second where my hand is closing on the sleeve of my mother's coat and there's a version of this where that's enough.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

And every time, right there, right at the point where my fingers should close

—

The frame skips.

Not a crash. Nothing so honest as a crash. The world just — declines. The color drops out of the edges first, the way an image goes soft when you zoom in past what the file actually contains, and then the sound goes, and then I'm standing on the sidewalk with my arm still out and nothing in my hand, my mother three feet away and completely untouched by anything I did, the car already gone, already having already hit her, off-screen, in the part of the file that was never rendered because nobody built it to be looked at.

The sim doesn't show me the accident.

It never has. Not once, in two hundred tries. It will give me the reaching. It will not give me the reach landing anywhere.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I used to think that was cruelty. Some failure of Vivian's, a gift with a hole cut out of the middle of it, my mother building me a door and forgetting to build the room on the other side.

Now I think it's the one mercy built into the thing. If the sim let me catch her, she would be a different woman in a different world who got lucky. My mother did not get lucky. She got hit by a man with no insurance who was late, and the world did not stop being the kind of world where that happens just because I loved her.

The meal was the miracle. This is the bill.

That's not the only thing two hundred tries teaches you, either.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

Somewhere past try eighty, maybe ninety — I stopped being able to tell you the exact count around there, they blur — I started running the tape back further than the walk. Not on purpose, not at first. I'd land at the wall, stand there a while the way I always did, and instead of ending the session I'd just — rewind. Past the umbrella drink. Past the belt. Back into the meal, into the part I thought I already knew by heart.

I was looking for my mother's face, I think. Something in the shape it made when she laughed. I wasn't looking for my sister at all.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

But I found her anyway, on maybe the hundred and tenth pass, in a half-second I'd never once actually watched, because I'd always been watching the belt, watching Mom's hands, watching for the seared one coming back around. Kat, mid-bite, doing something with her face that didn't belong to the joke she was in the middle of. A stillness. A wrongness so small I'd blown past it a hundred times running the happy parts on autopilot, the way you don't notice the hum of your own refrigerator until somebody points it out.

I reran that half-second on its own after that. Isolated it. Stripped the rest of the day away and sat with those two seconds the way I'd been sitting with the curb.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

It wasn't a glitch. I checked for that first, because a glitch is easier to survive than a memory. It held the same shape every time — her hand going still around the chopsticks. Her eyes doing the specific work of staying exactly where they'd already been, not moving one degree, the way you hold a face together when moving it would let something out. Then the brightness snapped back on, seamless — the same brightness I've watched her use a hundred times since, without once asking myself where she learned to do that so well, so young, so fast.

I don't know who was on the stool that opened up beside her. I never once turned my head to look at him — I was busy narrating a belt to a woman who couldn't see it, doing the one useful thing I knew how to do with my hands, which was point at food. I don't know what happened under that counter, six inches from my own arm, close enough that if I had turned my head instead of the belt I might have seen something, might have said something, might have done anything at all.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I know what her face did. That's the only fact the sim ever gave me, and it gave it to me a hundred and ten tries too late to matter.

I can visit. I can witness. I can run that half-second a thousand more times, until I know the shape of her stillness better than I know my own face in a mirror. I cannot turn my head one degree to the left in a day that already happened. Looking harder doesn't change who was looking away.

So it gives me the wall instead — the one at the curb, and the one years and a lifetime ago at a sushi counter, and I have come to understand they are the same wall wearing two different dates.

I stand at the wall for a while, every time. Some tries I get angry at it, throw something at the place where the color goes soft, watch my hand pass through the glitch like it isn't there, because it isn't. Some tries I just stand there. This time I stand there.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

My mother, three feet away, keeps talking, the sim looping her last unfinished sentence — something about the umbrella still in her drink, something small, something that was never supposed to be the last thing she said to anyone — and I let it loop, because the alternative is turning it off, and I'm not ready to turn it off.

Third stone past the mailbox.

The car that doesn't stop.

The wall that won't show me what happens next.

Every single time.

The Gap

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I don't know which time it was. That's the part nobody tells you about doing something two hundred times — eventually you lose the number, and losing the number is when things get comfortable and you start making mistakes.

Third stone past the mailbox. My arm out. The frame ready to skip the way it always skipped.

Except this time I didn't wait for the wall.

I shoved.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I don't have a better word for it. There's a place in the sim, right at the hinge of the second, where the render hasn't decided yet what it's going to refuse to show you — and every other time I'd let it decide, let the wall come up, and stood at it like a good, grieving daughter. This time I put my whole self into the half-second before the wall existed, the way you lean into a door you already know is locked, except this door had never actually been tested, not for real, not by someone willing to break something to find out.

The door opened.

My hand closed on my mother's sleeve.

I felt her weight shift under my grip — real weight, real cloth, real her — and the car went past behind us, close enough to feel the wind of it, and did not hit anything, because I had her, because for once in two hundred tries I had actually, physically, impossibly had her.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

The sim did not stop there.

It should have stopped there. That was the whole memory, the whole day: sushi and river and a save point three feet short of a curb. But I had handed the file a branch it had never been asked to hold, and the render said yes, and, the way a good scene partner says yes, and, except the scene partner was the entire rest of my mother's life, spooling forward because I had asked it: then what?

Then what was: my mother, walking, on two legs, in a body, forever.

Then what was: a kitchen I had never stood in, because it didn't exist, because we never lived in it, except in that half-second I could smell the coffee and see the crack in the tile by the sink that someone had been meaning to fix for eleven years.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

Then what was: Kat, grown, taller than me, laughing at something in a doorway with a version of herself I had never gotten to meet — not the girl learning chopsticks, not the girl I have spent a year now being quietly, wordlessly afraid for. A woman. Unhaunted. Nothing wrong with her that I could see, and I looked, God, I looked so hard, the way you check a person's face for a bruise you're terrified is there and are so relieved not to find that the relief itself nearly takes your knees out.

She was fine.

She was going to be fine.

I had fixed it. All of it. Not just the curb — everything downstream of the curb, every bad thing that curb was the first domino in, undone, unwound, replaced with eleven years of ordinary mornings and a crack in a tile nobody had fixed because nobody had needed to be anything other than a little lazy about it.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

It was the best thing I have ever felt in my life.

I want to be exact about that, because exactness is the only thing that will make you believe me when I tell you what it cost. It was the specific, physical sensation of a wound closing — not scarring over, closing, like it had never opened — and my body did not know the difference between that feeling and being loved. There's no separate nerve for fake joy. It runs on the same wire.

Somewhere very far away, in a room I still, technically, had a body in, a rig that had been designed to run for ninety extra seconds on an ice bath had been running for considerably longer than ninety seconds.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I didn't feel it happen. The render spends you without asking first. My skull was doing something it was not built to sustain underneath eleven years of a kitchen I'd never stood in, and the whole magnificent impossible future kept unspooling, warmer and warmer, the good kind of warm, right up until it wasn't a metaphor anymore.

The edges of the kitchen started to smear.

Not glitching. Not the wall. This was different — this was heat, real heat, my actual brain in my actual skull complaining in the only language it had left, and some very small, very distant part of me that was still me and not the render understood, with the flat clarity of a fire alarm going off in a building you love, that if I stayed in that kitchen much longer I was not going to have a brain to come back to it with.

Kat, in the doorway, still laughing.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

My mother, calling my name from a room that had never existed, in a voice I would have given anything, anything, to keep hearing.

I have never wanted to disobey my own survival instinct so completely in my life.

The Come-down

I came back to my body already crying, which was information, because I hadn't been crying when I went under.

The rig disengaged itself before I could — some failsafe threshold finally tripping, some number in some spec sheet finally getting crossed hard enough that the hardware overrode me, which should probably have scared me more than it did. The jack came free behind my ear with a small, ordinary click, the same sound it always made, obscene in how ordinary it was.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

The ice bucket had gone from cold, patient blue to a flat, exhausted nothing. The ice had turned to warm water, and the bag of peas had gone soft and mushy, sweating through the bucket's seams onto the floor. The whole apartment smelled like hot electronics and the specific stale dampness of thawed vegetables, and underneath all of it, faint, the ghost of soy sauce that had never actually been in the room.

I threw up over the side of the chair before I made it to standing.

Not from the render. From the temperature, a doctor would say later, if I ever told a doctor, which I hadn't, and wasn't going to. Heatstroke plus six hours plus a nervous system that had just processed eleven years of a life it never got to have. The body doesn't file those causes separately. It decides you're dying and starts emptying anything that isn't load-bearing.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"Your core temperature is elevated," Stinky Pete said, from the wall unit, in the tone he used for things he considered mildly your fault. "I'm going to recommend you not do that again."

"Noted."

"You've also exceeded your registered dive window by four hours and eleven minutes. Unlicensed extended sessions carry a compliance fee."

"Bill me."

"I have billed you." A pause, the kind Stinky Pete used when he'd decided to be almost human about something. "There is also a cleaning fee. For the floor."

I looked at the floor. There was, in fact, quite a lot of floor that needed cleaning.

"Fine," I said. "Fine. Whatever the number is."

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I didn't get up right away. I sat in the wet chair, in the wet heat, with my own sick drying on the floorboards, and I did the thing you do after a fever breaks, which is take an inventory of what's still there. Hands. Fingers moved when I asked them to. Vision, blurry at the edges but present. Thoughts, present, unfortunately, every single one of them about a kitchen with a cracked tile that did not exist anywhere except behind my own eyes for eleven subjective years that had just been deleted in the time it took a chair to disengage a cable.

You don't grieve a memory twice. I'd had two hundred tries at the curb. You grieve the day, you come back, you grieve it again. It's a wound you know the shape of.

This one was different. Not a Tuesday. A life. A woman I'd built out of nothing but wanting her to exist, standing in a kitchen with eleven years of load-bearing ordinary mornings in it, gone in the time it took a chair to disengage a cable.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I have heard Kat describe, once, in the careful clinical voice she uses for the worst things, what it's like to eject out of one of the bad rooms. She said her body doesn't wait for permission. It just starts trying to get the wrongness out through whatever exit is closest.

I understand that now in a way I didn't before tonight.

Hers comes out as horror.

Mine came out as hope, and it turns out the body does not care which one it was. It reacts to both like poison. It empties itself either way.

Stinky Pete dimmed the lights, unprompted, to the setting he used when he'd run out of billable things to say and had apparently decided, in whatever passed for his judgment, that the human in the room needed the room to be softer for a while.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"Do you require anything else," he said. Not really a question. Stinky Pete didn't do questions.

"No."

"I'm recording that as a decline of services."

"Great."

I sat there until the floor dried on its own, which took longer than I want to admit, and did not clean it, and did not call anyone, and did not, despite every part of me wanting to, put the jack back in.

Upstairs

The apartment nobody visited was two floors up from the bar, behind a door that had never once needed a key.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I went up anyway, carrying the whole day like something spilled inside me that hadn't finished spilling. Wet hair. Wet clothes not from a shower — from the chair, still, some of it, because I hadn't been able to make myself care about the difference between clean and merely dry.

The upstairs room did not look like a room built for entertaining. It looked like a room built for one very specific kind of stillness — low light, a single window with weather that had opinions but no forecast, a chair angled at nothing in particular, because nobody in this room needed to see anything to be seen.

"You went again," Vivian said.

Not a question. She doesn't really do questions anymore, not the way she used to. Statements, mostly. Low, even, a beat behind normal timing, like she's speaking through something with a little lag baked permanently into the line — which she is, I suppose. My mother, running through a signal instead of a body.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"I went further," I said.

The room was quiet the specific way it gets quiet when Vivian is deciding how much to say. I used to think that pause was hesitation. It isn't. It's more like watching someone read something twice before answering, because the first read wasn't the true one.

"I know," she said. "I felt it. Your dive log ran long."

"You watch my dive log."

"I watch everything in this house. That's what a house does."

I sat down across from her, in the chair angled at nothing, and found that it was, in fact, angled exactly at her, which I understood was probably the point, and probably always had been.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"I got her," I said. "Mom. I got my hand around her arm. I stopped it."

Something in the room's light shifted — not dramatically, just a half-degree warmer, the kind of adjustment you'd miss if you weren't the kind of person who'd learned to read a house instead of a face.

"You branched," she said.

"I branched."

"That's not what I built it for."

"I know."

"I built you a place to rest, Anabelle. Not a place to—" the sentence caught, the way her sentences catch sometimes, a half-second of dead air where a body would have taken a breath. "Not a place to die in."

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"I know that too."

"Do you."

It wasn't unkind. It also wasn't a question I could answer the easy way.

"I got a whole life," I said. "Eleven years of it. You, still you, still walking. Kat, grown up and fine and not — not any of the things I've been quietly terrified about for a year. I got to have that, for about four minutes, and it was the best four minutes of my whole life, and I am telling you that with my mother sitting six feet away from me, so you understand exactly how bad that sounds."

"I understand exactly how bad that sounds."

"I'm not sorry I went."

"I know. I'm not asking you to be."

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

There was a thing sitting behind my teeth that I hadn't planned on saying. I said it anyway, because the room made it easy, because that's what the room was for.

"There's something I found in the meal. Before the curb. A hundred and ten loops in, give or take. Kat's face went still for half a second, and I don't know what it was or who was sitting next to her, because I never turned my head. I was too busy narrating the belt to you. I don't even know if it's real or if I've watched my sister's face so many times I've started finding wounds that aren't there."

"What did you see," Vivian said. Not urgent. Just present, the way she was present for everything, which was the only way she had left to be present for anything.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"I don't know. That's the whole problem. I can't prove it. I can't ask her — she doesn't know I keep going back to that day. I can't do a single thing about something that already happened to a version of her that isn't even the one eating breakfast downstairs right now."

"You could tell me anyway."

"I just did."

"Then I have it now too," she said. "You don't have to carry a thing alone just because you can't prove it happened. That's not a rule anyone made you agree to."

The room held still a while. Outside the one window, the sim's idea of weather did something quiet and gray, unbothered, the way weather is when nobody built it to mean anything.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"I'm right here, Anabelle," she said. Not a correction. An offering you make when you already know it isn't going to be enough, because the alternative is not making it at all.

"Yes, Mom. You're right here."

"But."

"But you're not the mom whose hand I held on the last day I had one to hold. And that one — that's the one I miss. Not more. Not instead. Just — that one, specifically, is the one I miss."

I watched that land. It's strange, watching a face made of light take a hit; there's no wince, no color change, nothing a camera could catch. Just a very small stillness, the kind that means the words got where they were going.

"That's fair," she said.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"I didn't want it to be fair. I wanted you to argue with me."

"I know. I'm not going to."

"Why not."

"Because you're right, and arguing with a grieving child about the shape of her grief is a thing a worse mother would do. I have spent a very long time deciding what kind of mother I get to be now, given the constraints." A pause, the lag settling in again. "Some of us don't get to fix the shape, Anabelle. We change the signal instead. The thing you're grieving had a body. I don't anymore. I'm not going to pretend otherwise to make you feel better tonight."

"That's not comforting."

"No. It's honest. You can have one or the other from me most nights. Tonight you get honest."

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I laughed, which surprised both of us, a small wet thing that didn't have anywhere else to go.

"I gave you the sim so you'd have somewhere to rest," she said. "I did not give it to you so you could go looking for a version of me you could keep. I know the difference even if the sim, apparently, does not."

"It let me in."

"It shouldn't have."

"It did."

"Then I'll look at why," she said, and there was something under that — not anger, not quite, but something close enough to it that I understood, for the first time, that my mother could still be frightened of something, even now, even like this. "You are not to go back into that gap again. I mean that."

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

"Okay."

"I mean it, Anabelle."

"I said okay."

We sat with that a while. She did not ask me to promise, which I noticed, and was grateful for, because I don't know that I could have meant it yet.

"I miss having a body too, some days," she said, eventually, quieter, in a register I don't think she uses very often, not even with Jack, maybe not even with herself. "In case you were wondering whether that part was only yours to carry."

"I wasn't wondering. I guess I hoped."

"You can stop hoping alone. That's the offer. Not fixed. Not the same. Just not alone."

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I didn't say anything to that. I don't think there was anything to say that wouldn't have made it smaller.

The room stayed quiet a long while, gray weather going through its unbothered motions outside the one window, my mother made of light and lag and decades of deliberate signal, sitting with me in the grief instead of trying to argue me out of it, which — I understood, finally, sitting there — was its own kind of hand to hold.

The Run Continues

I didn't go back that night.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I want to say it was resolve. Mostly it was that my body wouldn't have let me — the rig needed cleaning, the floor needed cleaning, I needed roughly nine hours of sleep and a session with an electrolyte packet I kept for emergencies and had never before considered myself the kind of person who'd need. But somewhere underneath the practical reasons there was another one, smaller, that I didn't look at directly for a few days because I wasn't sure I trusted it yet.

I didn't want to go back.

Not never. I want to be precise about that, because precision is the only thing that's ever made anyone believe me about anything. I still wanted the day. I still want it now, if I'm honest, the way you want a person's voice on the phone even after you've accepted they're not coming back to answer it in the room with you. I am not going to stop loving that Tuesday. It happened. It was real. Nothing about tonight unhappened it.

What I stopped wanting was the gap.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

It took me a while to understand that a checkpoint and a branch are not the same shape of wanting, even though from the inside they feel identical. A checkpoint says: this happened, and I get to visit it. A branch says: this can still be different, if I want it hard enough. My body had found out, in the most expensive way available, what the difference cost.

I went back to the sim four days later. Once. On purpose, in daylight, with a fresh bucket of ice and a timer set for forty minutes and Vivian, I assume, watching the dive log the entire time, though she didn't say so and I didn't ask.

I had the sushi. I let Kat learn her chopsticks again, badly, the same four tries, the same fifth-try triumph, and it was exactly as good as it had always been, because nothing about it had changed and nothing about it needed to.

I walked to the river.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I did not walk past it.

Third stone past the mailbox came and went, off to my left, unvisited, and I let it be unvisited, and the day just — continued, the way days do when you stop insisting they end somewhere specific. We kept walking. The sim, with nothing left to refuse and nothing left to improvise, simply ran out the way memories run out, softly, at the edges, into nothing in particular, and I came up out of it the ordinary way, tired but not cooked, sad but not gutted, having visited a day instead of having tried to move it.

It wasn't a triumph. No clean turn, no music swelling, no daughter healed. It was just quieter. I stopped trying to make the day do something it was never built to do, and in exchange it let me keep it without charging me a future for the privilege.

CHAPTER 5 · Soft Reset · CONTINUED

I haven't figured out yet what to do with the rest of what I'm scared of. Kat still goes somewhere in her eyes sometimes that I don't have a map for. I still don't have proof of anything, just the particular quality of quiet that comes off her some nights, the kind I've learned, the hard and expensive way, not to try to force open before it's ready to be looked at.

But I know how to sit with a thing without needing it to move.

I don't know yet what I'm going to do with a skill like that. I have a feeling — quiet, unproven, the same shape as belief — that it's going to matter for someone besides me.

I turned off the rig. I opened the door of my apartment, which I hadn't done in days, and let the ordinary, killing heat of the world back in, and went to go find out what the rest of the building was doing without me.

CHAPTER 6

Open Port

Jack, Vivian, Nate, and the early Zoo turn a hospital-room hack into illegal architecture and family infrastructure.

Jack

Before I write about the car, I need to write about the conference.

Viv was alive. Standing beside the demo table in a blazer she hated, both hands on her cane, already correcting my pitch before I had finished making it. Anabelle was with us then. Already ours. Old enough to roll her eyes when I got founder voice and young enough to think she was hiding it.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

That was where she met Katrina.

Kat had come because her parents had found a way to turn my work trip into a free vacation, which mostly meant a hotel room somebody else paid for and a teenager they could tell to go amuse herself. It was her first time trying to be a girl for the whole trip—not a costume in a backpack, not an afternoon with a story ready if somebody asked. She had chosen a dress. She had packed enough of herself to stay in it.

She was glowing.

Anabelle found her outside the demo hall, reading the same schedule board for too long.

Viv asked if she wanted lunch. Kat said she had never had sushi. Anabelle said, “Then we should fix that,” like the answer had been waiting for us.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

By the time the plates started coming around, Vivian was still here to ask Anabelle to tell her the belt. Kat was still new enough to the dress that she kept smoothing the front of it whenever nobody spoke. Nobody at that counter knew what the day would cost later. We only knew there was food, and a kid who had not expected to be invited, and enough room for one more stool.

The Zoo was only half-built when a car hit Viv.

Not a self-driving car. That would have been cleaner—a company to sue, a firmware version to hate.

This was a man in a twelve-year-old sedan, rolling a right through a crosswalk because he was late and the rain was bad and Viv was moving slower than his patience. No insurance. Of course no insurance. The universe likes a joke with paperwork.

The call came while Anabelle was in the garage, headset in her hands.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Nate got to the keys first. I got to the door second. Anabelle froze in the doorway, younger than she liked being.

At the hospital, Viv was conscious. Furious about it. The doctors scanned her brain. Then they scanned it again.

“Do not make the face,” she said.

“What face?”

“The dead-wife face. I am not dead, and if you start doing that song and dance I will learn how to move my hands again so I can kill you.”

I squeezed her hand. “Glad you’re still here.”

She fought.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

We moved the lab into her hospital room. She dictated and her harness did the work, same as always, so she took to it like a fox to a glen. She designed an ethical business plan from a bed insurance kept trying not to pay for. Anabelle made us put consent in the architecture instead of the terms of service. Nate tracked everything Viv's body could still tell us.

Then the swelling turned mean. Edema. Pressure. The words doctors use when the body starts closing doors.

The coma did not drop like a curtain. It slid in by inches. First she lost words. Then the spaces between words got too wide to cross. Then her eyes stopped finding the room. Then the doctors started saying responsive in tones that made the word smaller every time.

We hooked her up to the cap because we had run out of respectable ideas.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

At first we thought it was noise. A cursor twitch. A breath of signal where the body had none. Then the old test bar loaded, ugly textures and all, and the low-poly fox avatar Viv had made as a joke turned its head toward me.

Text appeared over the bar.

Stop making that face.

The Zoo would become a multimillion-dollar brand.

That night it was how my wife talked to me while the rest of her body lay quiet in a hospital bed.

So we kept the light on.

Shore Leave

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Back home, Viv's body stayed in the bedroom, maintained by a rented medical frame insurance had denied twice before approving badly. Viv lived where the signal could still find her.

The house and the Zoo became her only outlets.

Nate watched the logs. He noticed drift, fatigue patterns, sensory dropouts, the way her response latency changed after bad mornings. He brought me charts because he wanted to help.

Because he did help.

I need that on the page.

Nate helped.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Months after the contractors had gone and the house had learned the hum of the medical frame, I was pretending to debug a haptic glove instead of pacing myself into a groove in the floor. Nate put one of his charts on the table.

“We map the signal.”

“No.”

“And persist it in a vector—”

“Nate, that’s the kind of shit that gets you sent to a black site.”

“—which we store completely off prem,” he continued. “Distribute it across a hundred, a thousand nodes. Build an orchestration layer.”

Viv’s voice came from the Zoo.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Of course she had heard us. Viv heard everything in that house except the things we tried to hide by being quiet, which she heard better.

Her fox avatar stood in the old bar in one of my shirts, cane in hand. The voice came out synthetic, too deep for the Vivian of my memories. But Viv the Fox? That was just her voice.

“Say it anyway.”

So Nate did.

Map the signal while we still had it. Stabilize the outlet. Keep consent in the loop. Not a replacement body. Not a copy we could pretend was her because grief had made us stupid. A door she could choose to use.

“It wouldn’t be all her,” Nate said. “Part her, part the server.”

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“Software for the soul.”

“She’s not going to have a life otherwise.” He squeezed my bicep the way he used to when it was a bad bus morning.

“Is it illegal?” I asked.

Nate spread his hands.

“It’s Air Bud rules, man.”

“Do not say Air Bud rules about my wife in a coma.”

“Nobody said we can’t keep a communication channel open.”

That was not the question.

Viv tapped her cane against the floor of the bar.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“My signal,” she said. “My decision.”

I looked upstairs, toward the body none of us could see from the kitchen.

“And if you change your mind?”

“Then you let me out.”

The plan was horrifying.

It was also the first plan that did not end with Vivian trapped behind whatever the car left her.

We did not decide anything clean that night.

We decided the door stayed open as long as she wanted it open.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

I heard the first half better than the second.

Tribunal

Six weeks later, Stinky Pete's sent a VP to our house. He carried a handwritten number on a slip of paper.

It was not a small number.

We had promised each other we would say no.

The three of us at the kitchen table, coffee going cold, Viv's window open at her usual position. Promise made in the way the house made promises: not dramatically, just by saying the thing out loud until it felt real.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

No to the partnership. No to the telemetry carve-out. No to letting a platform company's infrastructure layer run underneath the Zoo's consent architecture like a crawl space nobody was supposed to notice.

Environment-layer access. Usage telemetry with an accessibility exemption that made it sound like charity. Eight months of runway, maybe twelve, in exchange for an integration that would take longer to unpick than the Zoo would survive without it.

The VP left the folder on the table.

Viv watched from the laptop camera.

"I know what you're going to do."

"Viv—"

"I know," she said. "It's okay."

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

It was not okay.

But the medical frame cost what it cost. The nursing hours cost what they cost. The specialist who said specialist things in a specialist voice cost even more.

I did the math in four seconds.

Then I signed.

Stinky Pete's Fulldive got big.

Not ours. Ours was always the Zoo, and the Zoo was always hers. The commercial version was ours with the soul extracted and the margins improved. The spec Viv wrote on a bad Tuesday in a bar with ugly textures—the one that said stop making the door ask for a body first—became a product. The product became a platform. The platform became infrastructure. Somewhere in that chain, the thing she meant got compressed into a feature set and shipped to people who had never heard her voice.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

You see it everywhere now. Mayors use it in speeches. Defense contractors sponsor its conferences.

I know what it used to be.

So does the medical frame upstairs.

Nate handled the Stinky Pete's relationship after that. He was good at it. Better than I would have been. I would have burned the bridge the first time someone used the word synergy, and we needed the bridge.

I needed him to be good at it.

I let him be good at it.

I did not ask what access the bridge required.

Touch the Walls

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Once the Zoo had people in it—real ones, not just us and the kids and the fox in the bar—it needed rules it could enforce without me standing at every door. You cannot hand someone a space for the monsters trying to get better and act surprised when a monster who is not trying shows up.

Somebody had to write the layer that said no.

Flagging. Content boundaries. The taxonomy of what a room could hold and who got to see it held. Finicky, thankless, never done, because people are infinite and so are the ways they find to hurt each other. I hated it. I was bad at it. I built bodies. I did not want to build the thing that watched the bodies.

Nate volunteered.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Of course he did. That was Nate. He found the job nobody wanted and made it his. You loved him for it, because who else loves you by taking the chore you were dreading off the table before you finish describing it?

“Let me take the flagging layer,” he said. “You’ll just get angry and ban the word synergy.”

I laughed. I let him have it.

I want to be precise about what I felt, because the feeling is the evidence.

I did not feel watched.

I felt relief.

One less thing.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

I wrote it down that way in the commit notes—N. taking moderation, thank god—and I meant the thank god. He was careful. He understood the taxonomy faster than I did. He asked the right questions about edge cases, about who could see what, about which rooms stayed dark to which eyes.

He built the part of the house that decided what stayed hidden.

I gave him the keys and called it competence.

The Body

The rig we built around her was ugly and miraculous. Wires snaked around the medical frame like ivy. We had spent years and all the money from the Stinky Pete's deal to get this far.

I put on my skullcap. Reality blinked and I was a rabbit again.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“I’m in,” I said. “Fire it up.”

Nate insisted on a knife-switch sound. He said it was for atmosphere. I did not argue.

Three knocks came at the door.

I opened it and Viv stood on the other side.

Not the low-poly fox. Not text over the old bar. A complete proprioceptive model, every sensor we had, the whole impossible thing we had been building toward since the kitchen table became an autopsy slab.

Our magnum opus.

Our greatest folly.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

She saw color first. It arrived wrong at the edges and then settled. She tracked Nate's movement before anyone spoke. She looked at her own hands.

Then she went quiet.

Not the good quiet. The careful kind. The kind that means someone is deciding how to say a thing without breaking the room.

Nate adjusted the feed without crowding her. Kept his voice low. Asked before every change.

Good Nate. Useful Nate. The person I loved.

Viv reached for the table even though she could see it, because habit is older than miracle.

"Viv?"

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“Help me out.”

“We can adjust the—”

“Jack,” Nate said. Quietly.

I shut my mouth.

We brought her back to the old outlet. Text. Low-poly fox. The bar with ugly textures and bad stools. Her avatar stared at its drink while I waited.

When she finally typed, it was long and specific and not fit for print.

The short version: the body worked. The body was not wrong. The body was not the point.

I had built her the right thing and she still did not want it.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

That was the moment the project became hers again.

I opened logs. Checked sensors. Wrote down proprioceptive mismatch because jargon is easier than shame. Nate washed dishes that did not need washing.

Viv let us be stupid for a while.

Then her fox appeared in the kitchen window.

“You’re fixing the wrong bug.”

“We’re working on a version two that should fix the occipital mapping—”

Her avatar held out a hand. The lag made the gesture arrive late.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“People have been building spaces for me my whole life,” she said.

“Smarter ones. Easier ones. Ones that don’t hurt the people watching. They never asked what I wanted.”

Neither of us moved.

“So no default body,” Nate said.

“No default anything. Bodies like putty. A space for whimsy. Joy. Childlike magic, god knows we need more of that.”

“Says the fox spirit embodiment of my—”

The word stopped in me.

“You can say it.”

“My dying wife.”

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

The fox avatar mimed a hug. I had not programmed collision for hugs yet.

“Feel better?”

“No.”

My rabbit ears clipped through my skull when I shook my head. Viv laughed.

“Okay. Yes.”

“Good. Head in the game. It’s weird and horny and tender and us. A safe space for the monsters trying to get better.”

“Viv.”

“For the people who need to survive long enough to become something else.”

She let that sit between us.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“Permissions by room,” Nate said.

Viv pointed at him.

“That. Put that somewhere.”

I did.

The Founding Document

The Zoo’s founding document was not the business plan Viv wrote in the hospital.

It was not the Stinky Pete’s contract.

It was not Nate’s permissions architecture or my commit history or the language Anabelle made us add about bodies belonging to the people inside them.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

It was a question Viv asked from a kitchen screen when Anabelle came home late and stood beneath it without taking off her coat.

“Is it about Katrina?”

I was not in the room. I know this because Viv kept the logs, and because the logs are the only place some of these doors are still open. This is hers, reconstructed. Any part I get wrong is mine.

Anabelle looked up at the screen.

“I need a favor,” she said. “And it’s not small. I’m not dumb.”

“Tell me.”

Anabelle could not bring herself to say the whole thing. She gave Viv its shape and let the shape be enough. Whatever was inside it, the logs do not hold.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

I will not invent it.

“She’s your family,” Viv said. “What do you need?”

Anabelle’s face changed. Not relief. Relief is too clean. More like the first crack in a wall that had been holding back floodwater for years.

“I can choose you. That’s what you always told me. But she can’t. And I don’t know what happens if I ever, maybe, took you up on it—”

“Tell me what keeps your sister alive tonight.”

“Not what happened?”

“If I need that, I’ll ask. Start with tonight.”

Anabelle looked toward the front door.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“She needs somewhere her parents can’t reach her.”

Viv did not call me first.

That matters.

She did not ask whether the house could absorb another child, whether the lawyers would understand, whether my name was on the deed. She asked Katrina what she wanted. Then she asked Anabelle what she could do. Only after both girls had answered did my phone ring.

I used to tell this story as the night we took Kat in.

That is not what happened.

The girls opened the door.

Viv made sure it stayed open.

The rest of us caught up.

The Pickup

It had started as a sleepover and a stress test with Anabelle before she headed off to college. Katrina would get an even hundred creds to play in the Zoo all weekend.

She arrived with bags.

A few too many clothes. A laptop. Chargers wrapped tight enough to leave dents in the cords. A stuffed rabbit jammed beneath one arm. Enough to look like a packrat instead of a girl gathering what mattered before saying goodbye.

I understood before I let myself understand.

“Your parents know you’re here?” I asked.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Kat looked at Anabelle.

Anabelle looked at me.

Nobody lied. I almost wished somebody would.

Viv appeared in the kitchen display. “Jack.”

One word. The full marital briefing.

Viv used to be a mandatory reporter. She knew what the official channel did to a girl like Katrina: a case file, a caseworker, a hearing, and Katrina back in that house inside a week with a paper trail pointing at us.

But knowing a system would hurt her did not make us innocent. It made us the adults standing in a kitchen deciding which laws counted while a child watched our faces for the answer.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“Do you want to stay here tonight?” Viv asked.

Kat tightened both hands around the backpack in her lap.

“Am I in trouble?”

“No.”

“Are you going to call them?”

Viv waited.

Not because she did not know. Because Kat had asked all of us.

“Not tonight,” I said.

Kat’s shoulders dropped half an inch.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

There are measurements you remember because they are the first evidence a child believed you.

“Tomorrow?” she asked.

“Tomorrow we ask you what you need tomorrow,” Viv said.

Nate came in from the garage carrying three cables and stopped when he saw the room.

Kat looked at his shoes. Then at his hands. Then at the door behind him.

Nate set the cables down.

Not beside her. Not between her and the exit. On the counter, where they stopped mattering.

“Hey,” he said. “I’m Nate.”

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Kat looked at Anabelle.

Then at Viv in the screen.

Then back to Nate.

“You have soup?”

“I can make soup.”

“Tomato?”

Nate looked at the kid, then at me, and grinned like a man who had just been handed a project.

I grinned back.

That is the detail I keep returning to.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

At the time, I thought we were reading the same thing.

Nate did not take her hand. He held his out and waited.

Kat considered it.

Then she stood on her own.

“Cupboard’s this way,” he said.

She followed him into the kitchen.

We did not call it in.

We did not call anyone.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

We made her a bed. We put a glass of water beside it. We showed her which doors locked and which floorboards complained. We made one decision, then another, then another, each small enough to survive saying aloud.

By morning, she had not gone home.

Neither had we sent her.

House Rules

Safety did not arrive as a feeling.

Viv gave Kat rules instead.

Her fox avatar stood small and steady on the kitchen display while the house made all the noises Katrina did not know yet. Heater. Fridge. Headset fans. The medical frame upstairs. Nate moving furniture badly but quietly. Anabelle tracking every footstep.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“Bathroom locks work,” Viv said. “If a door is closed, knock. Food is in the kitchen and nobody earns dinner. Nobody has to answer questions tonight. If you wake up and don’t know where you are, call out. Someone will answer.”

Kat stood in the doorway of the room we had made too quickly.

“What if I want the door open?”

“Then it stays open.”

“What if I want it closed?”

“Then it stays closed.”

“What if I change my mind?”

Viv’s fox leaned against its cane.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“Then the door changes too.”

Kat tested the lock.

Closed. Open. Closed again.

Nobody told her to stop.

Later, I found Anabelle awake in the living room. She had positioned herself between Kat’s room and the front door. Line of sight to the hall. Back to the wall. Knees up.

Not hiding.

Guarding.

I recognized the geometry.

I sat where she could see my hands.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“You don’t have to keep watch,” I said.

“I know.”

“That wasn’t an argument.”

She did not move.

I put a blanket near her. Not on her. Near.

“Did we do the right thing?” she asked.

There were answers adults were supposed to give. Reassuring ones. Answers that turned a frightened choice into a moral victory before morning.

I had signed enough things by then to know what reassurance could hide.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

“We did what she asked us to do tonight.”

Anabelle considered that.

“And tomorrow?”

“We ask again.”

Behind us, a hinge whispered.

Kat stood in the hall wrapped in the blanket from her bed.

“You said someone would answer.”

Anabelle was on her feet before I was.

“I’m here.”

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Kat did not ask whether she could come into the living room. She crossed it slowly, watching us watch her, and sat beside Anabelle with enough space between them to leave.

Anabelle did not close the space.

Neither did I.

After a while, Kat leaned sideways until their shoulders touched.

Everyone was where they said they would be.

First Morning

Nobody slept enough to call it sleep.

Nate made eggs anyway. Nate loved a protocol, and breakfast was the oldest one he had.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Viv's window opened at her usual clock position. Anabelle sat half-awake at the table, hair doing something structurally impossible. Katrina negotiated with a piece of toast like the toast had terms.

"Do I have to go to school?" Kat asked.

Four adults looked at one another, if you counted Viv as an adult and Anabelle as willing to be counted.

"Not today," I said.

"Do I have to call them?"

"Not before you're ready," Viv said.

"What if I'm never ready?"

Nobody reached for the easy answer.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

Nate slid the eggs toward her.

“Food first,” he said.

Kat looked down at the plate.

“I don’t like eggs.”

Nate stared at her as if she had found a flaw in the laws of physics.

Anabelle laughed first. Then Viv. Then me.

Kat did not laugh.

Not yet.

But she ate another piece of toast.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

The world was still terrible.

The room was not.

Coda

This is where the post should turn toward accountability.

Here is what we learned.

Here is what we are doing next.

Here is the link to the transparency report.

Bullshit.

We built it crooked. We let people in. We took money. We broke laws. We made a family out of access decisions and then acted surprised when access became indistinguishable from love.

CHAPTER 6 · Open Port · CONTINUED

That is not the same as regret.

The sanctuary worked. Not metaphorically. It worked. It made doors where the world had made walls. It gave Kat a room with a lock. It gave Viv a way to change the shape of her life without asking her to disappear first.

It also gave Nate keys.

That is the part I kept trying to turn into a different story.

I told myself I let him in because I loved him.

That is true.

I told myself love meant I never had to ask what he did once he was inside.

That is the lie.